Trend estimation by penalized least squares

Theory · numerical computation · selection criteria · open problems

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Extended research-lecture notebook for discussion with the professor.

What the full lecture investigates

A mathematical and computational research notebook — intentionally extensive.

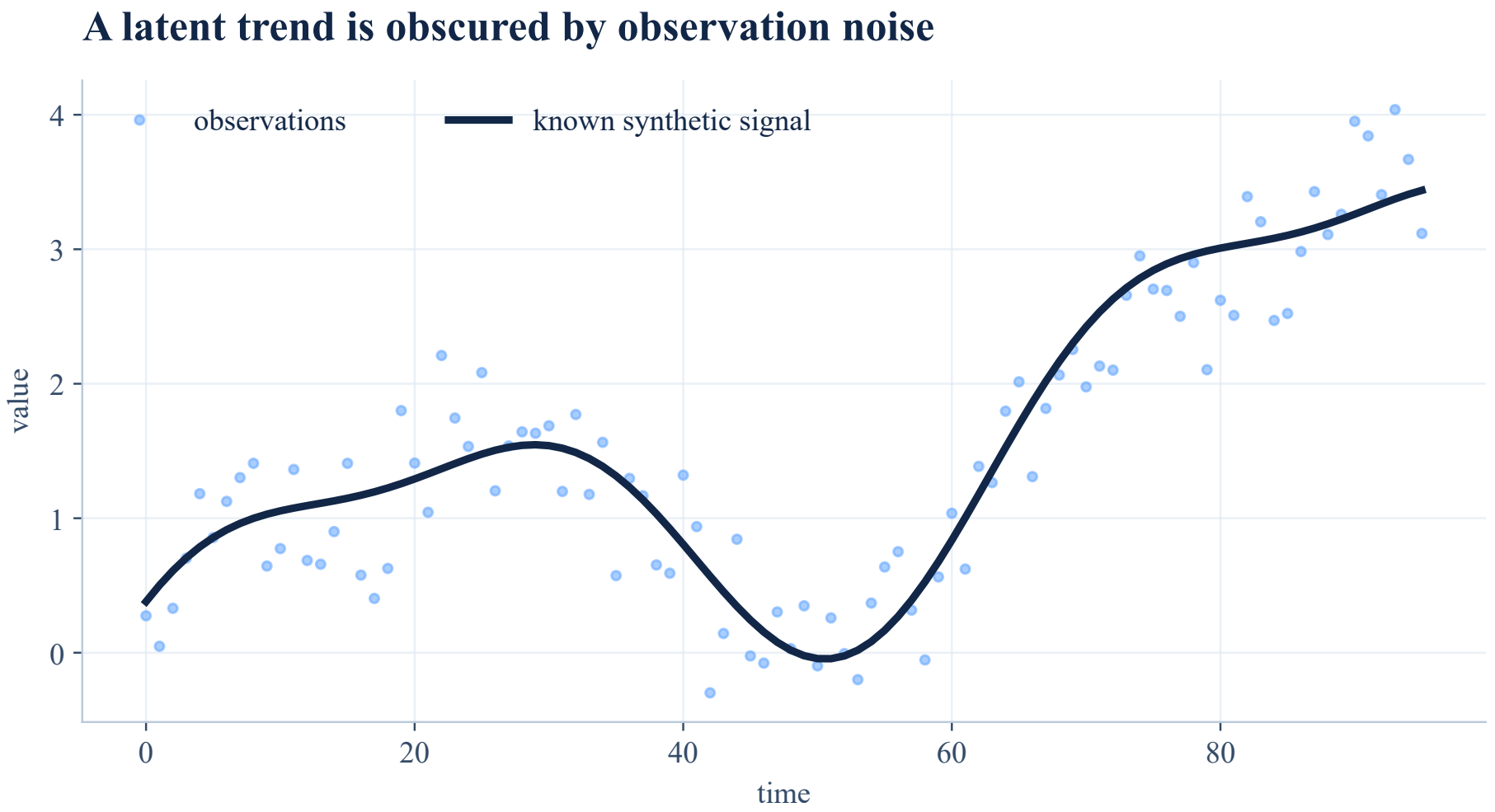
1. Motivation and the established PLS estimator.
2. Arbitrary finite-difference orders and reference means.
3. Affine solution, polynomial nullspace, SVD and cost.
4. Effective degrees of freedom and normalized smoothness.
5. Searching over penalty lambda or bounded smoothness S.
6. CV, GCV, AICc, BIC, Gaussian MLE and a deferred joint mean.
7. Fair runtime benchmarks, numerical conditioning and scientific examples.
8. What is new, what is known, and where research can continue.

Legend: established theory · implemented methods · tested numerical claims · future research.

I. Why estimate a trend?

From noisy observations to a structured, interpretable signal

Observed data versus latent signal



Deterministic synthetic data; truth is known only because the example is simulated.

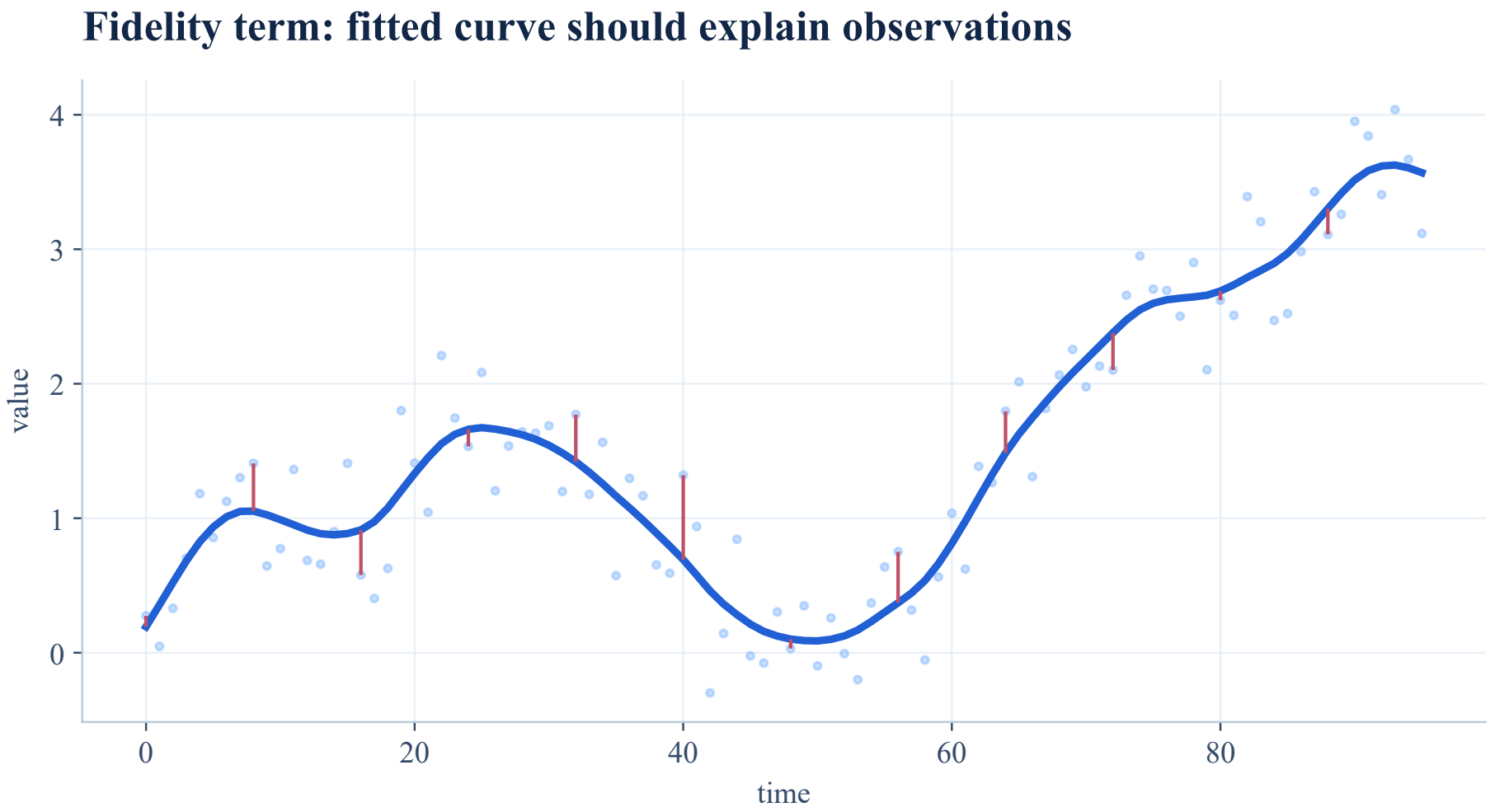
The fundamental observation model

$$y_t = \tau_t + \varepsilon_t, \qquad t = 0, \ldots, n-1.$$

- y_t: observation.
- τ_t: smooth latent component that we want to estimate.
- ε_t: remainder, not necessarily white noise.

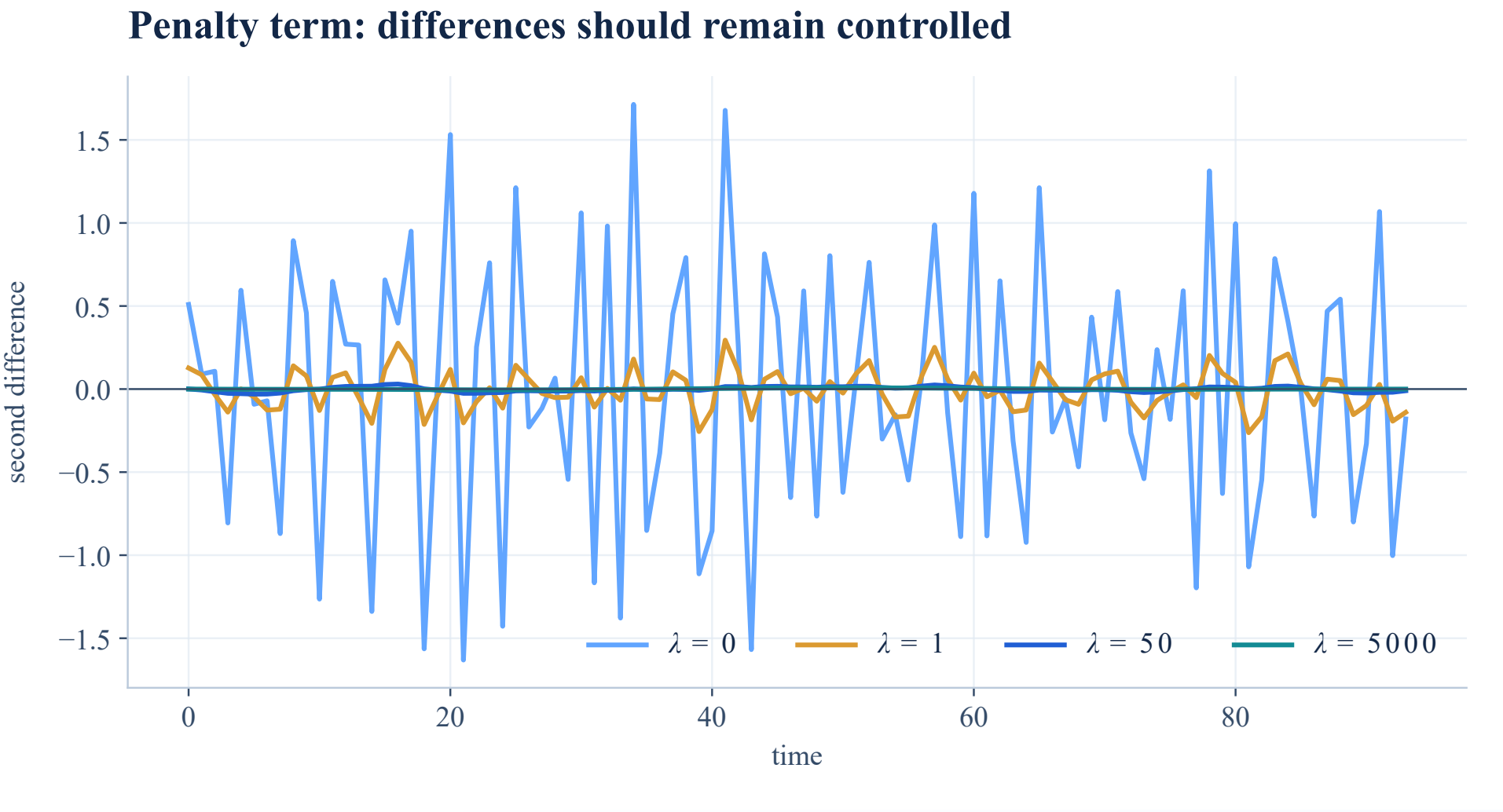
Our paper studies historical trend extraction, not demonstrated forecasting skill.

Fidelity to observations



Squared vertical discrepancies contribute to the data-fidelity term.

Why we also penalize roughness



The penalty is evaluated on differences of the FITTED series, not observations.

The single mathematical object behind this project

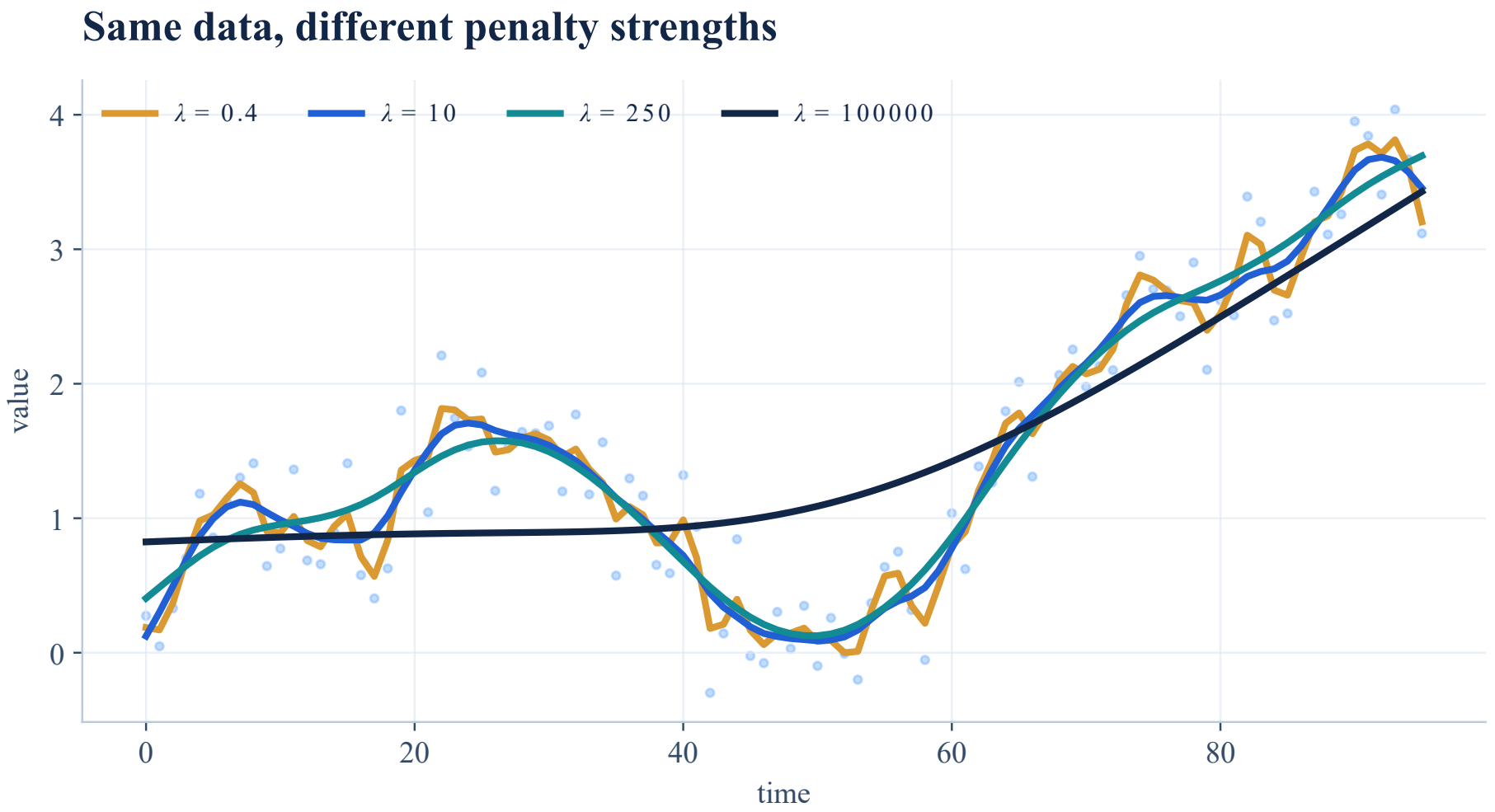
$$\widehat{\tau}_{\lambda,\mu} = \arg\min_{\tau \in \mathbb{R}^n} \left\{ \|y - \tau\|^2 + \lambda \|D_d \tau - \mu \mathbf{1}\|^2 \right\}.$$

Hyperparameters: order d, reference mean μ, penalty $\lambda \geq 0$.

At $\lambda = 0$ the model interpolates. As $\lambda \to \infty$ it approaches the affine difference constraint.

This PLS family is established theory; the library is not claiming to invent it.

How the penalty alters the trend



Same synthetic series; multiple positive penalties.

Historical contributions and attribution

Work	Established idea
Whittaker	Graduation using penalized differences
Guerrero	Reference differences and controlled smoothness
Cortés-Toto et al.	CV, GCV, AICc, BIC comparisons for PLS
Whittaker–Henderson literature	Banded computation, likelihood interpretation
Our project	Integrated implementation, analytical derivatives, safe numerical inversion, S search, reproducibility

Arbitrary order d, nonzero μ, polynomial nullspaces and spectral PLS are not individually new.

II. Understanding difference operators

What does the penalty actually enforce?

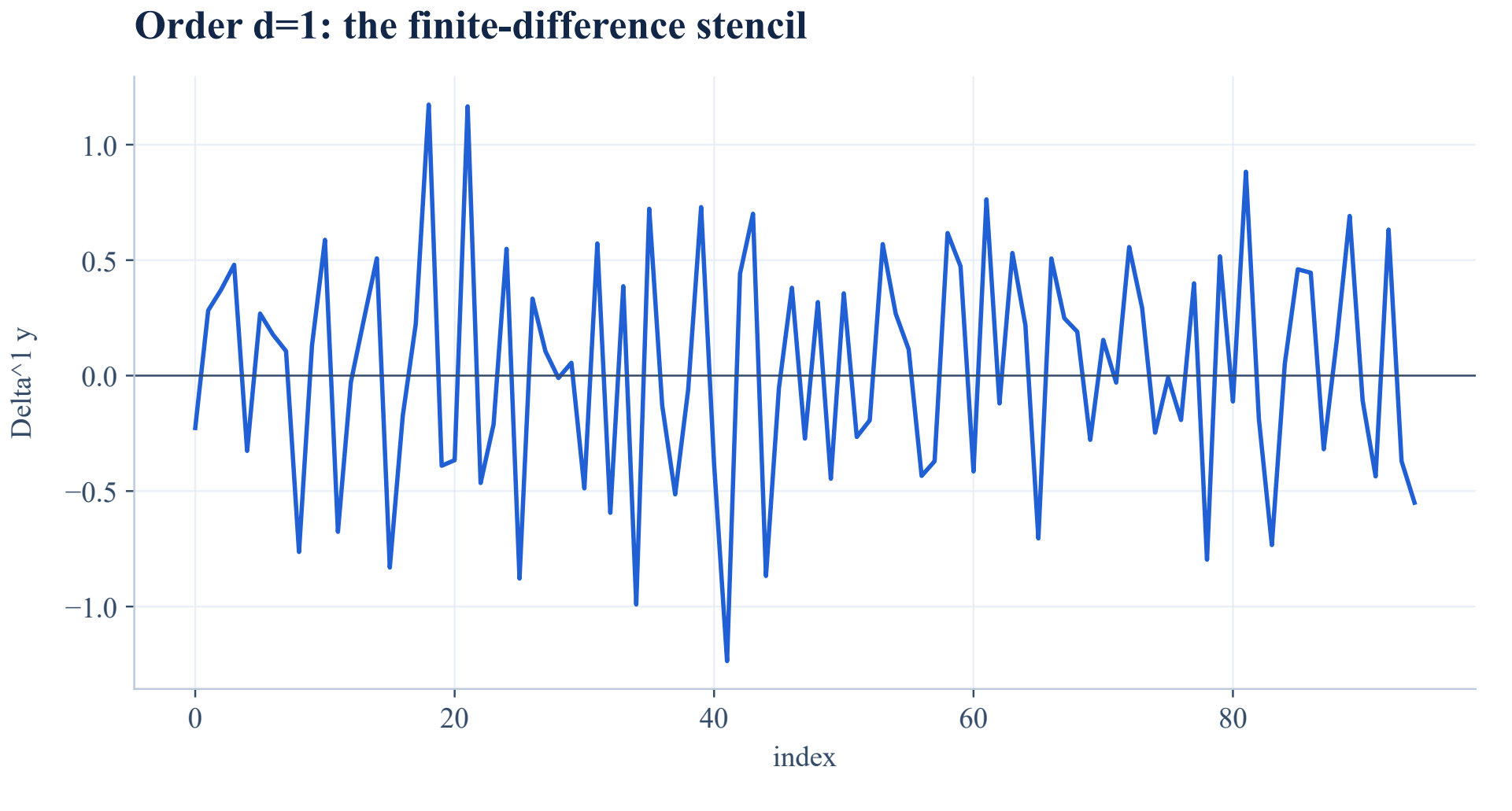
First difference operator

$$D_1\tau = (\tau_1 - \tau_0, \tau_2 - \tau_1, \ldots)^\top.$$

When $d = 1$ and $\mu = 0$, large λ discourages changes between adjacent levels.

$$\lim_{\lambda \to \infty} \widehat{\tau}_{\lambda,0} = \text{best constant fit.}$$

Visualizing first differences



First differences measure consecutive level changes.

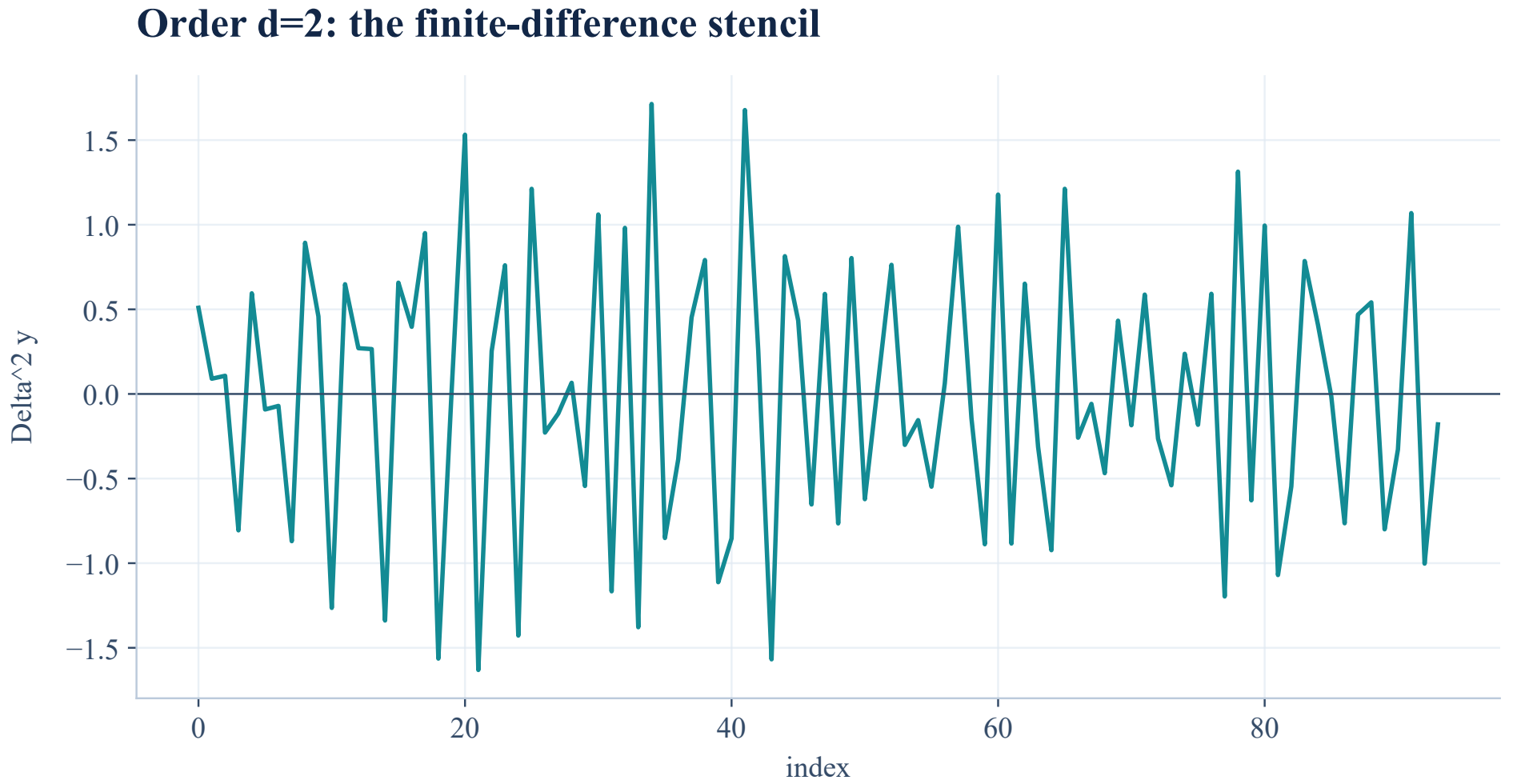
Second differences measure curvature

$$(D_2\tau)_t = \tau_{t+2} - 2\tau_{t+1} + \tau_t.$$

$$D_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & 1 & 0 & \cdots \\ 0 & 1 & -2 & 1 & \cdots \\ \vdots & & \ddots & & \end{pmatrix}.$$

A large centered second-difference penalty gives a **linear** limiting fit.

Visualizing second differences



Second differences detect local changes of slope.

Any admissible integer difference order

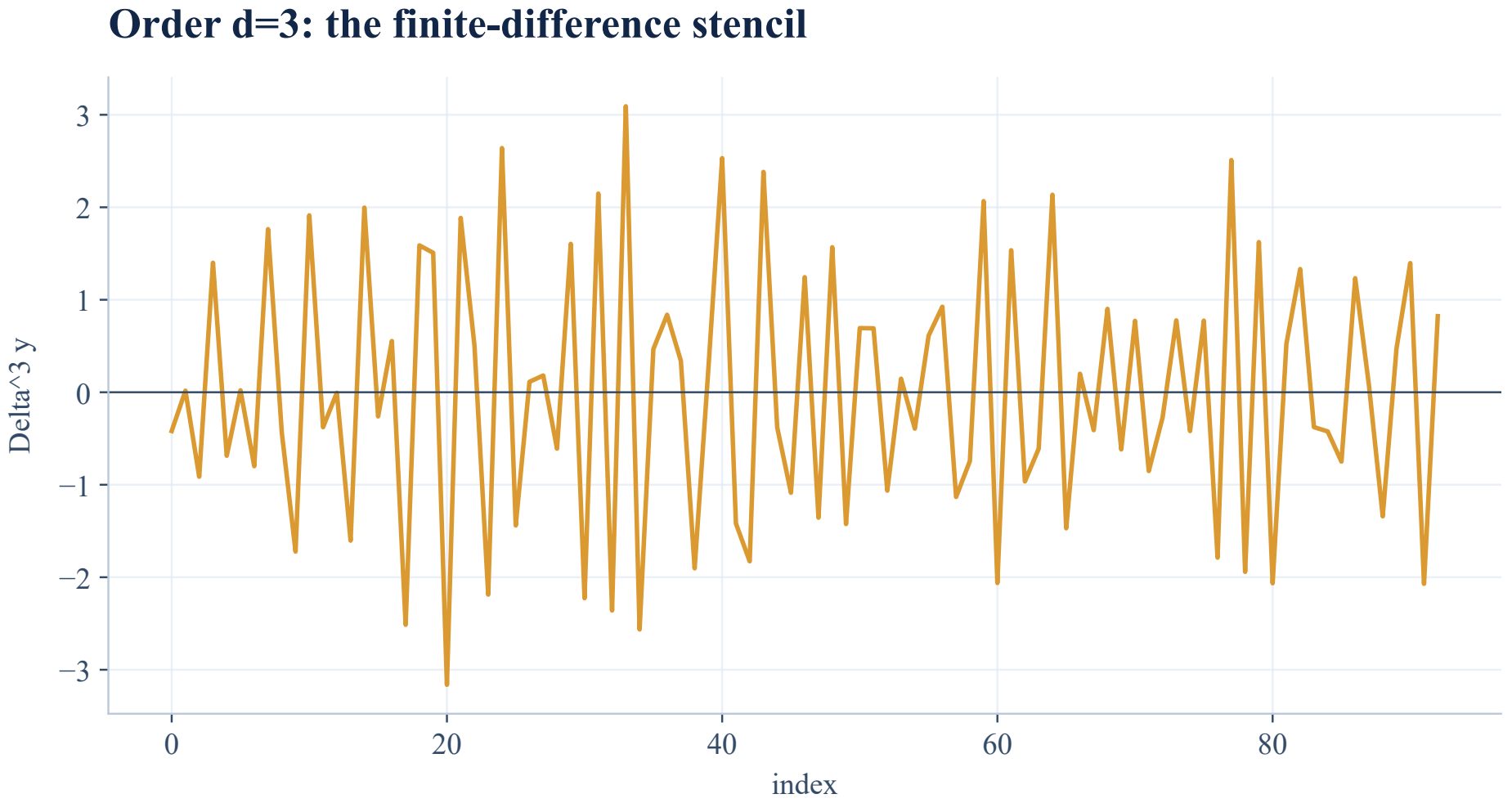
$$\boxed{(D_d\tau)_t = \sum_{k=0}^{d} (-1)^{d-k} \binom{d}{k} \tau_{t+k}.}$$

Examples: $D_1 = (-1, 1)$; $D_2 = (1, -2, 1)$; $D_3 = (-1, 3, -3, 1)$.

The implementation also handles $d = 0$, for which $D_0 = I_n$.

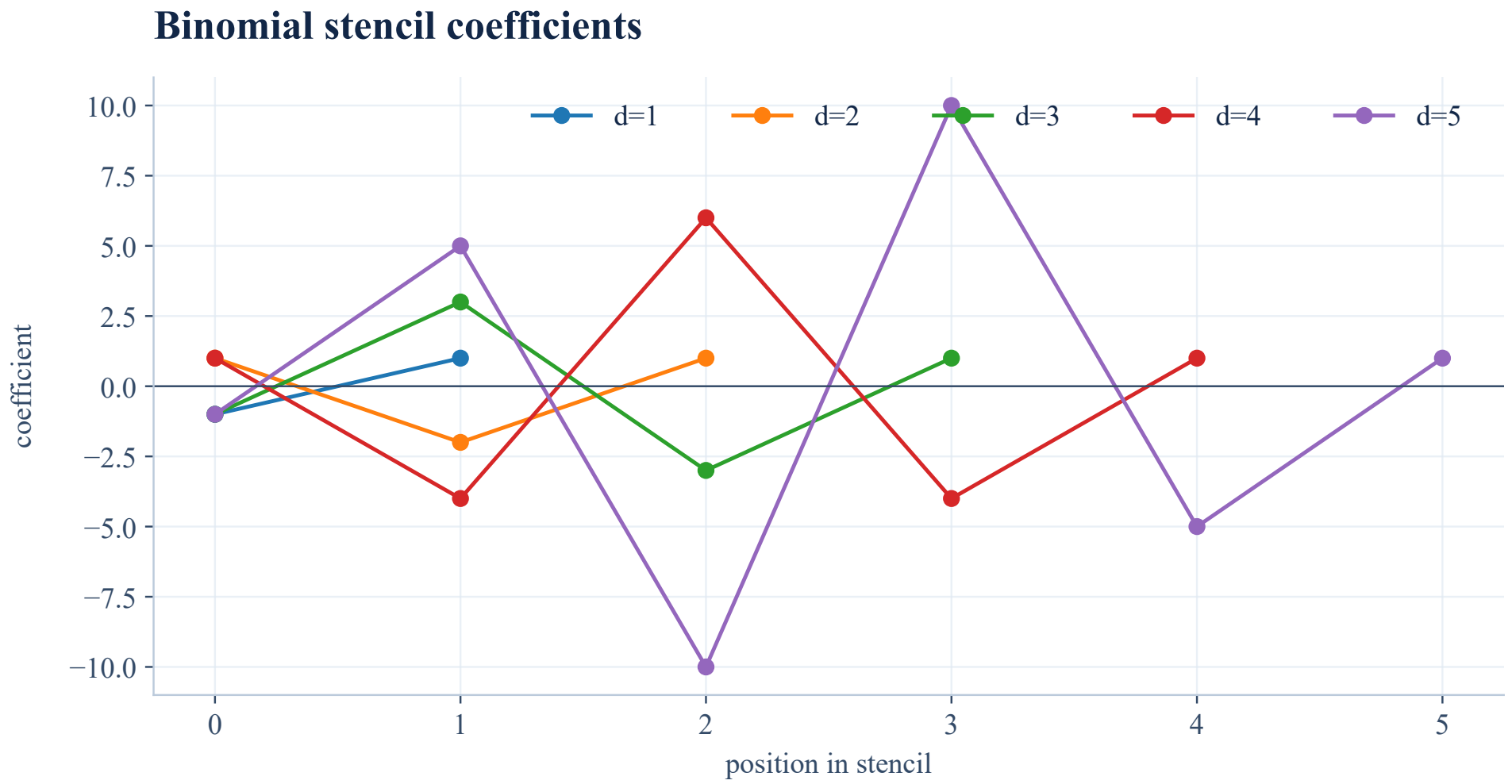
Numerical admissibility and floating-point reliability are different statements.

Third differences



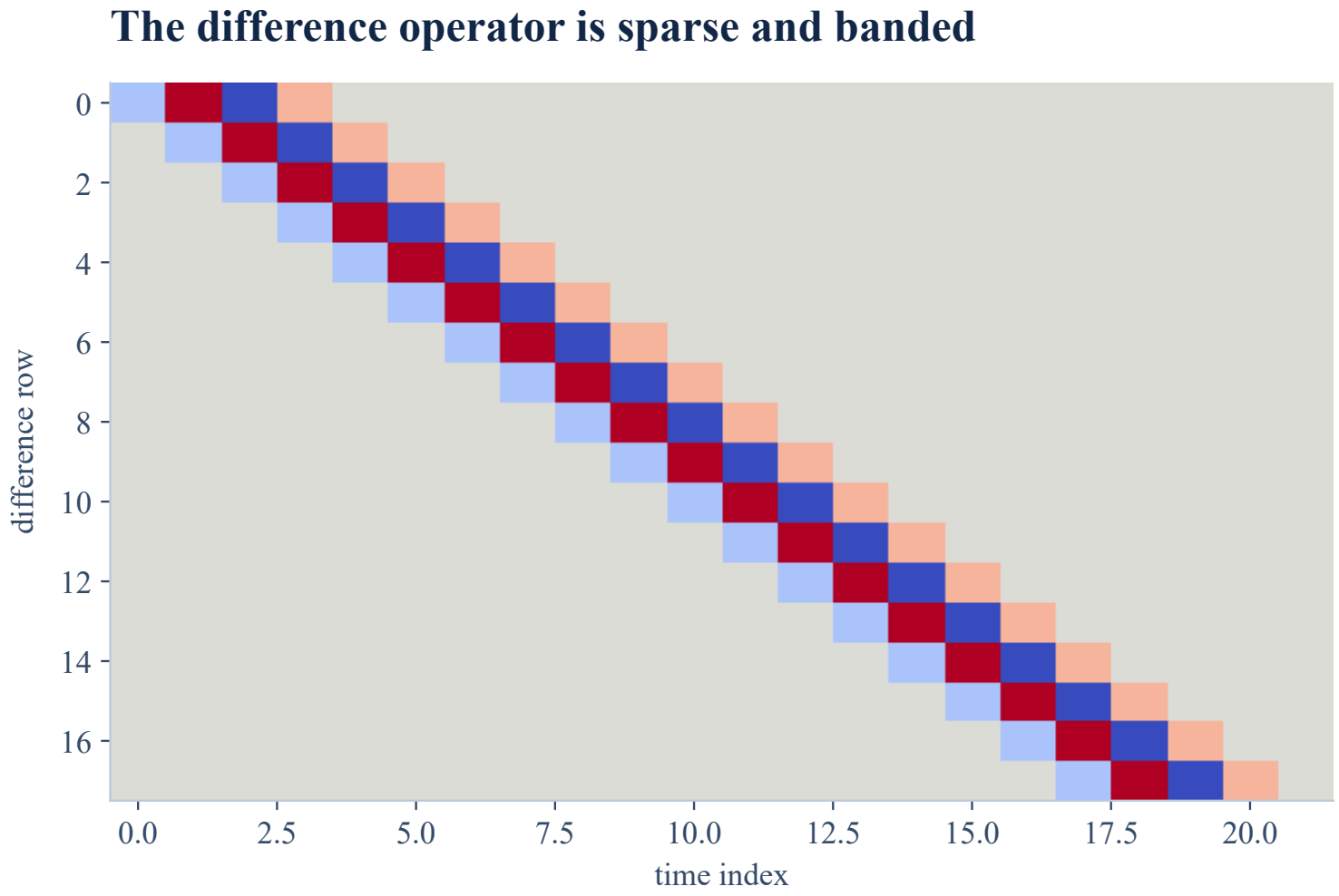
Third differences react to variation in curvature.

Higher-order binomial stencils



Large coefficients contribute to high-order numerical conditioning problems.

A sparse banded difference operator



Its structure is why banded linear solvers are strong baselines.

Proof: why exactly d zero eigenvalues?

For $1 \leq d < n$, D_d has $n - d$ independent rows:

$$\operatorname{rank}(D_d) = n - d.$$

Let $Q_d = D_d^\top D_d$. Since

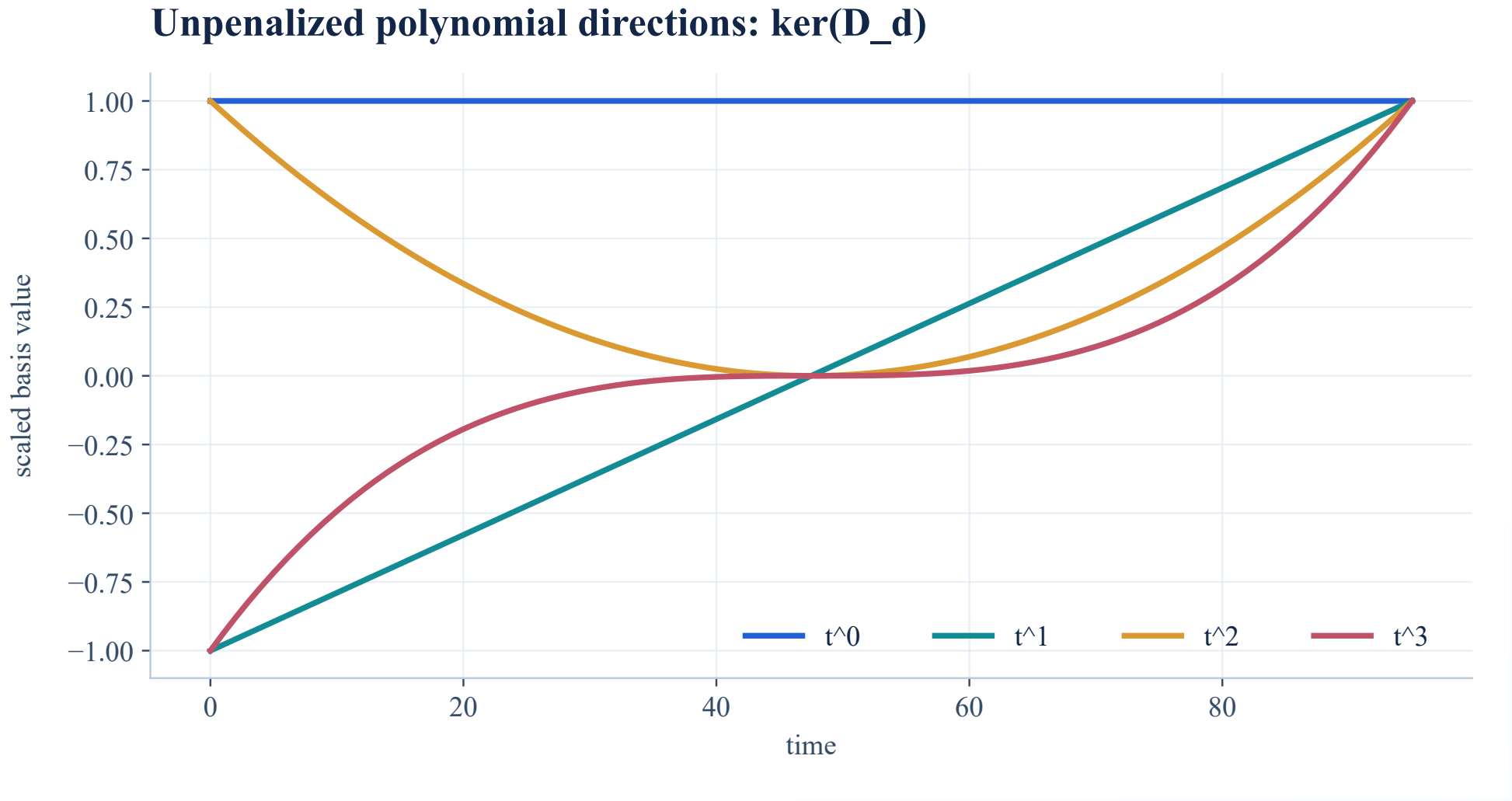
$$x^\top Q_d x = \|D_d x\|^2,$$

we have $\ker Q_d = \ker D_d$. Consequently,

$$\boxed{\dim \ker Q_d = d.}$$

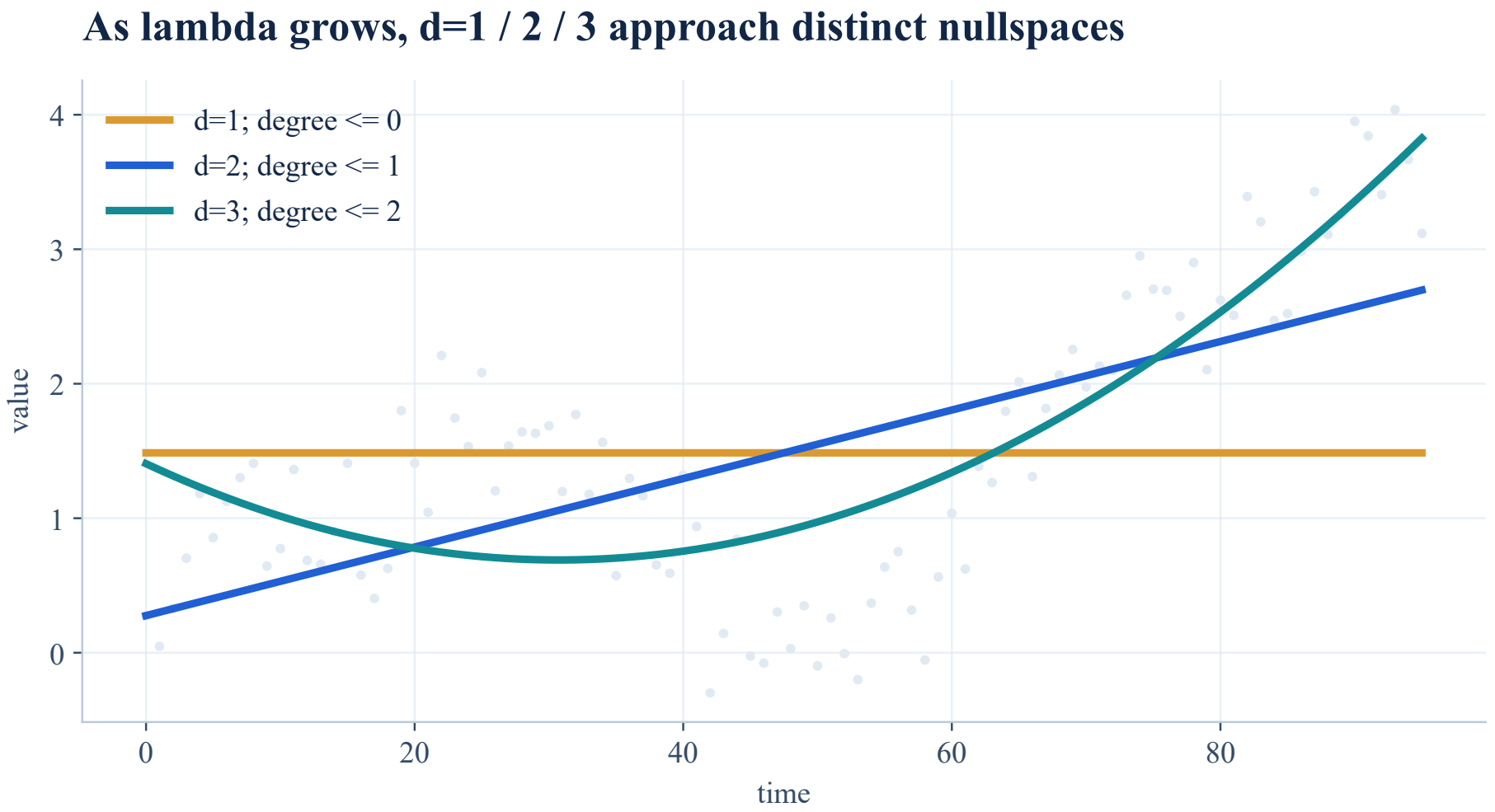
The result is exact algebra; numerical rank thresholds are a separate matter.

What is in the nullspace?



The basis 1, t, ..., t^(d-1) is annihilated by d-th differences.

Zero-mean infinite-penalty limits



Constant for d=1, linear for d=2, quadratic for d=3.

The nonzero mean difference is important

At infinite penalty,

$$\boxed{D_d \tau = \mu \mathbf{1}.}$$

With zero-based indices one particular solution is

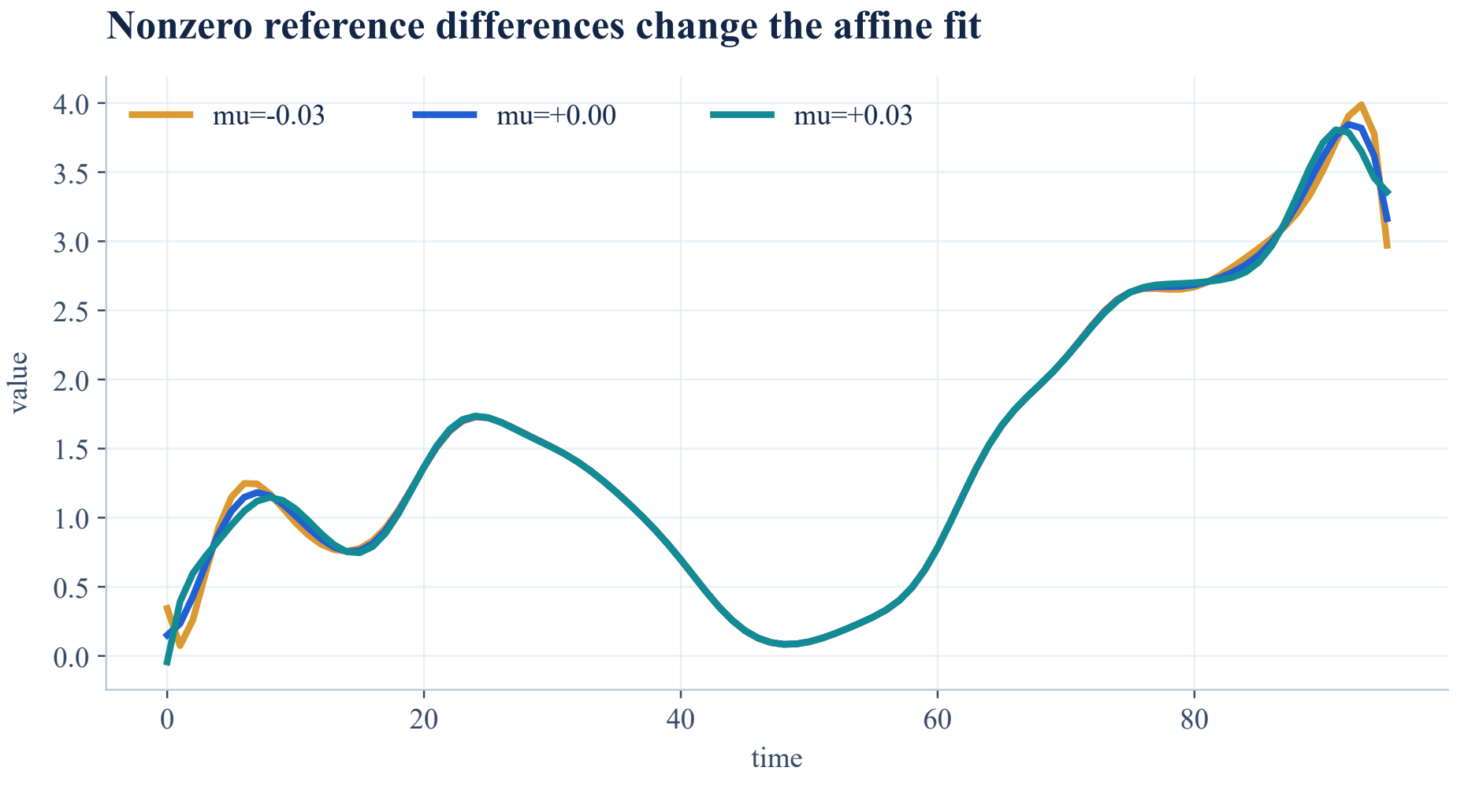
$$p_t = \mu \binom{t}{d}, \qquad D_d p = \mu \mathbf{1}.$$

Every limiting curve has form

$$\tau = p + q, \quad q \in \ker D_d.$$

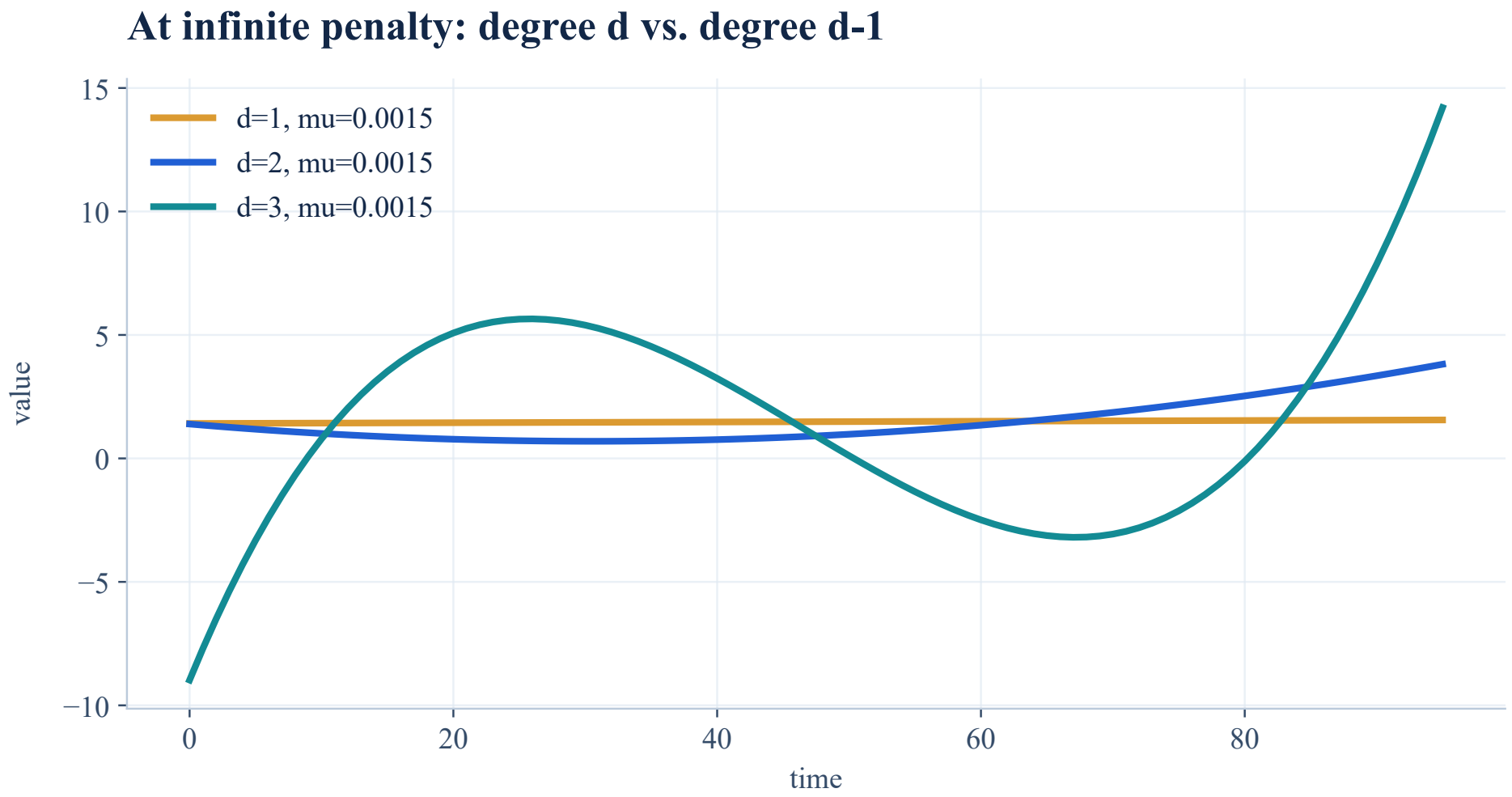
Thus $\mu \neq 0$ allows a **degree-d** polynomial component, instead of only degree at most $d - 1$. This property is established, but computationally useful.

Change the reference mean, keep order and penalty



The reference shifts the affine trend estimate.

The affine infinite-penalty limit for nonzero mu



Degree-d particular solution plus the d-dimensional nullspace.

Fixed mu, empirical plug-in, and future joint estimation

Mean	Meaning	Status
$\mu = 0$	Centered penalty	Implemented
Numeric $\mu \neq 0$	Prespecified mean differences	Implemented
$\mu = \text{mean}(D_d y)$	Observed-difference plug-in	Implemented in fitting and conditional MLE
$\widehat{\mu}(\lambda)$	Conditional likelihood-optimal mean	Derived, joint method not released

Data-derived mu is not automatically a joint maximum-likelihood estimate.

III. Deriving the affine estimator

From the quadratic problem to a reusable matrix

Eliminate the reference mean from the penalty

Take p with $D_d p = \mu \mathbf{1}$ and set $x = \tau - p$.

$$\widehat{x} = \arg\min_{x} \left\{ \|(y - p) - x\|^2 + \lambda \|D_d x\|^2 \right\}.$$

The remaining penalty is centered around zero. The shift p is explicitly known.

Differentiate the quadratic

With $Q_d = D_d^\top D_d$,

$$\nabla_x = -2(y - p - x) + 2\lambda Q_d x.$$

Setting $\nabla_x = 0$:

$$(I + \lambda Q_d)\widehat{x} = y - p.$$

Therefore,

$$\boxed{\widehat{\tau}_{\lambda,\mu} = p + H_\lambda(y - p), \quad H_\lambda = (I + \lambda Q_d)^{-1}.}$$

Derivative of the smoothing matrix

From $(I + \lambda Q_d)H_\lambda = I$,

$$Q_d H_\lambda + (I + \lambda Q_d)H'_\lambda = 0.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{H'_\lambda = -H_\lambda Q_d H_\lambda.}$$

This exact matrix identity is central to gradients of leverage, residuals and CV.

Meaning of H and its trace

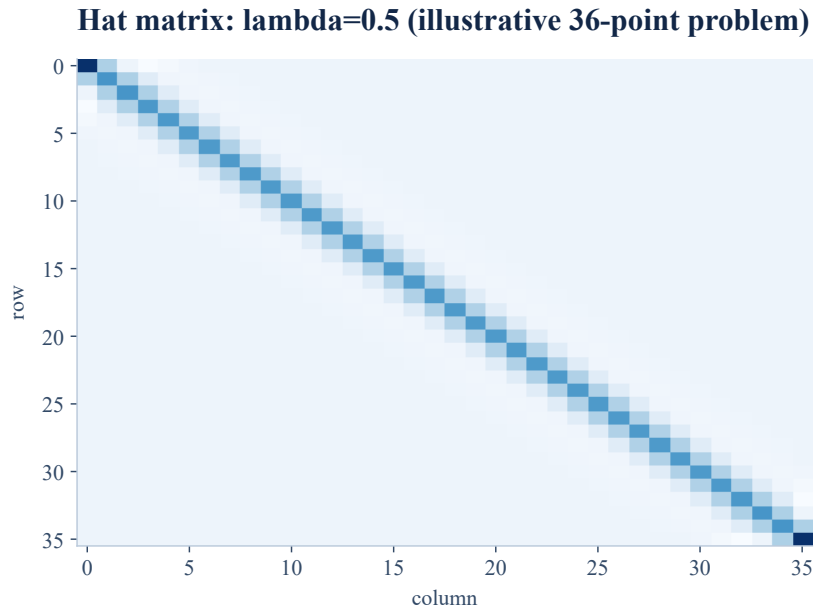
For fixed numeric μ,

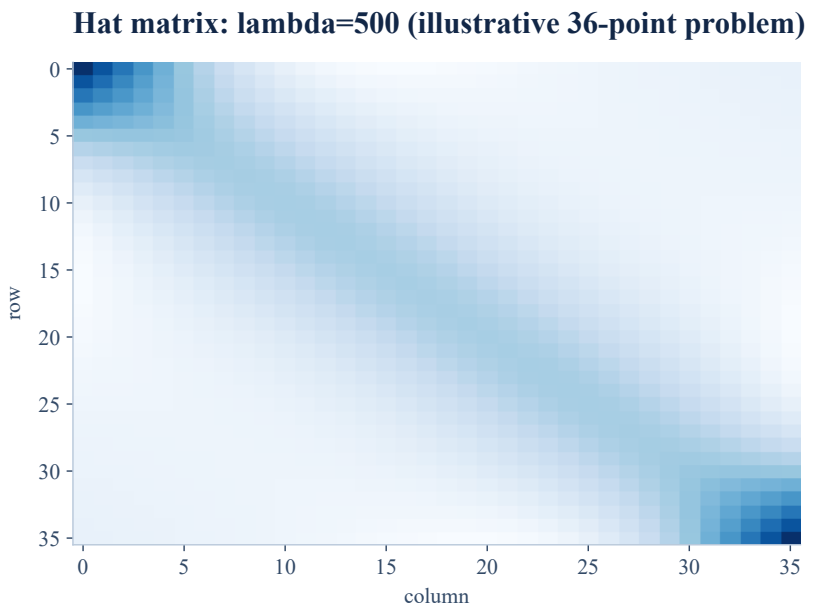
$$\widehat{\tau} = p + H_\lambda (y - p).$$

- H_λ is symmetric and positive definite at finite λ.
- Eigenvalues lie in $(0, 1]$.
- Diagonal h_{ii} gives the observation-space leverage.
- Trace $\nu(\lambda)$ is the **conditional effective degrees of freedom**.

If μ depends on the data, the full fitted-value sensitivity changes.

Weak and strong hat matrices





Observation-space H is generally dense, while the spectral attenuation matrix is diagonal.

IV. Spectral computation

The value of precomputing once and reusing many times

Diagonalize the penalty

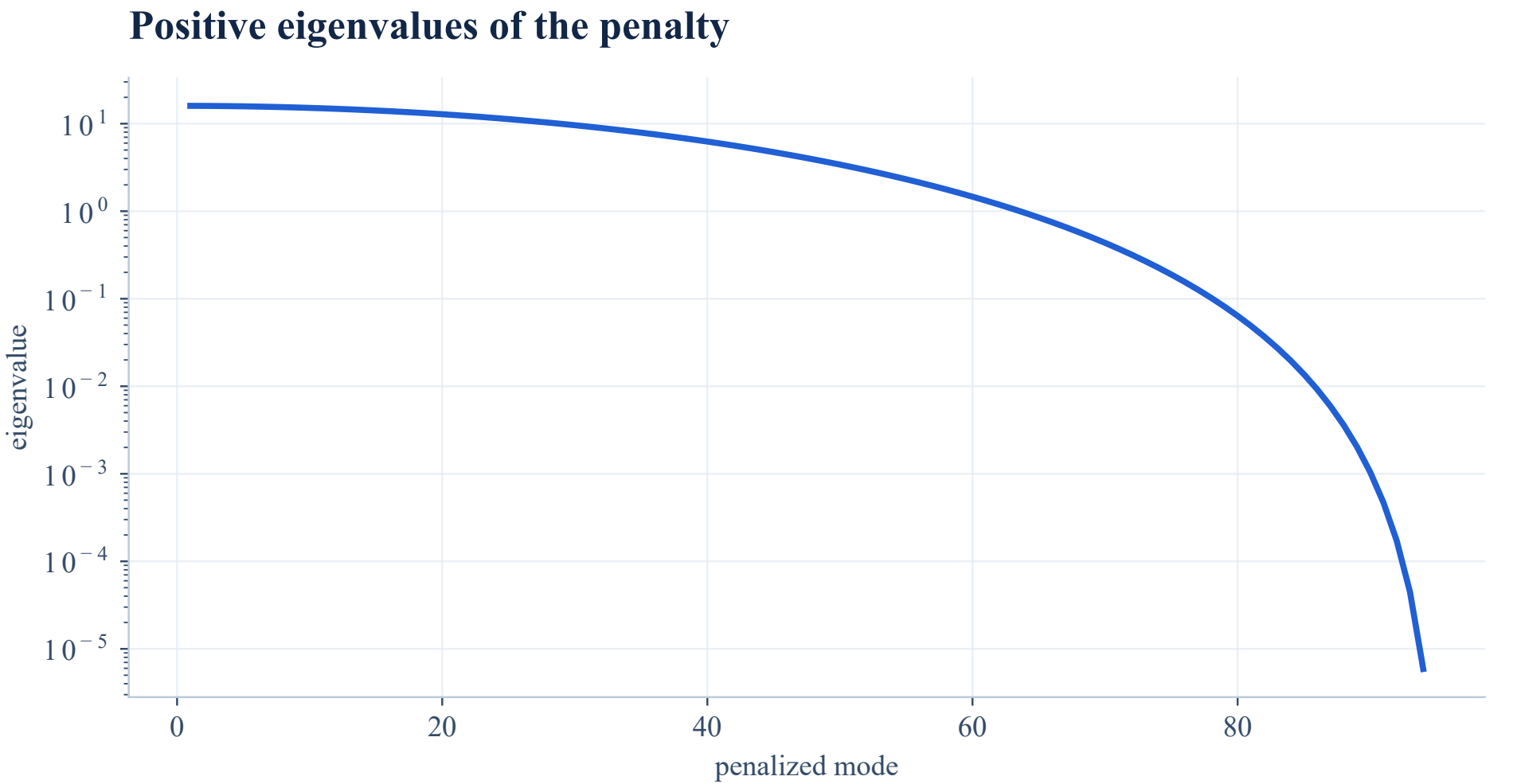
$$D_d = U\Sigma V^\top, \qquad Q_d = V\,\mathrm{diag}(\delta_j)V^\top.$$

Then

$$\boxed{H_\lambda = V\,\mathrm{diag}\left(\frac{1}{1+\lambda\delta_j}\right)V^\top.}$$

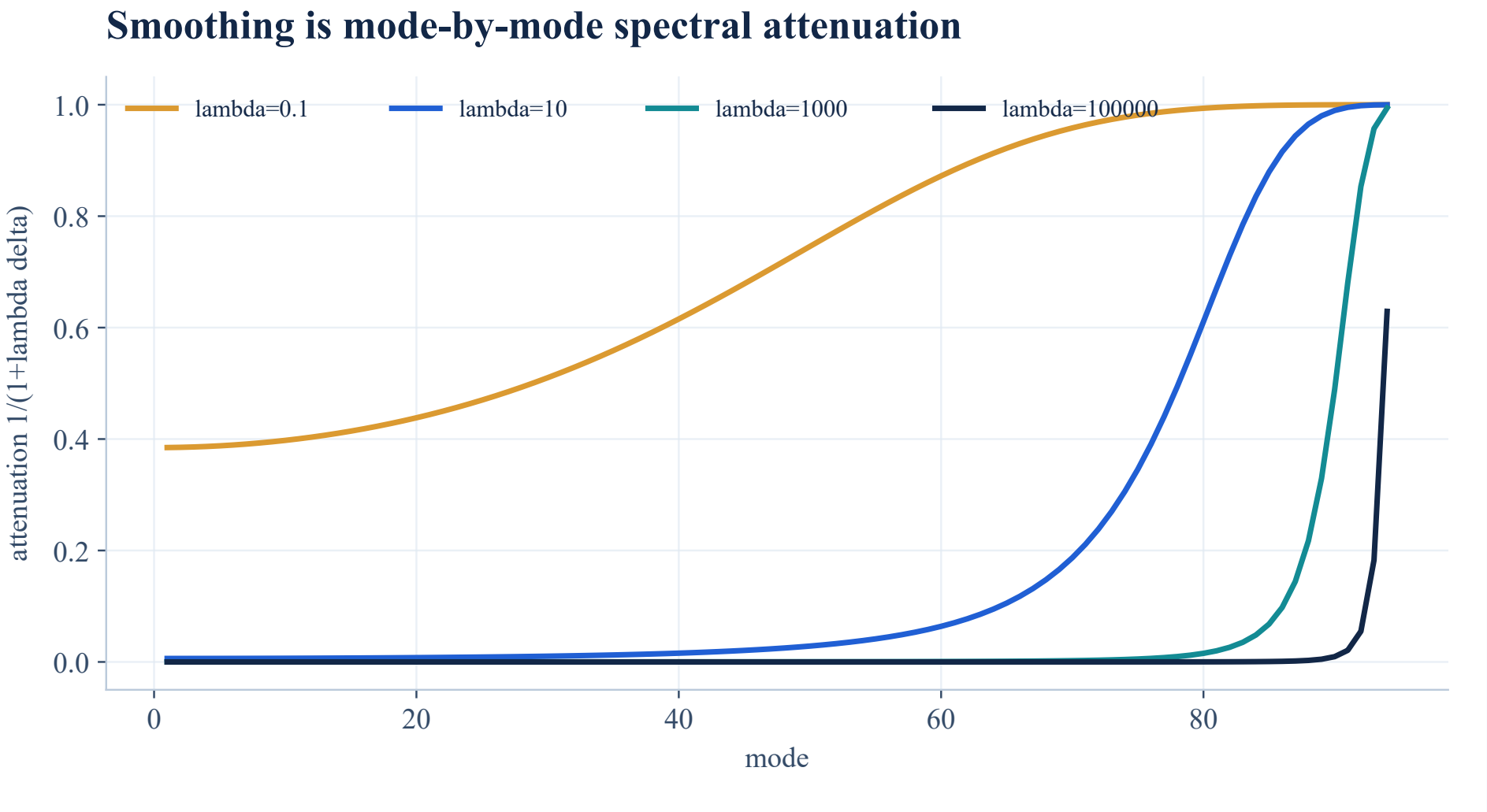
The eigenvectors do not change when λ changes.

The positive penalty spectrum



Positive eigenvalues δ_j for a seeded order-two example.

Attenuation of different spectral modes



Each mode is multiplied by 1/(1+lambda δ_j).

One projection, many candidate penalties

Compute $c = V^\top (y - p)$ once.

Then

$$\boxed{\widehat{\tau}_{\lambda,\mu} = p + V\,\mathrm{diag}(\alpha_j(\lambda))c, \quad \alpha_j(\lambda) = \frac{1}{1 + \lambda\delta_j}.}$$

The costly eigensystem is reusable, but reconstructing a full fitted curve still takes matrix–vector operations.

Cost accounting matters

Computational task	Leading arithmetic cost
Full SVD setup	$O(n^3)$
Eigenvector storage	$O(n^2)$
Single transformed data projection	$O(n^2)$
Scalar trace / smoothness / spectral GCV	$O(n)$ per candidate
Full trend reconstruction	$O(n^2)$ per candidate
Pointwise LOOCV leverage	Typically $O(n^2)$ per candidate

Cost is **not** identical to elapsed wall-clock time.

Two cheap scalar identities

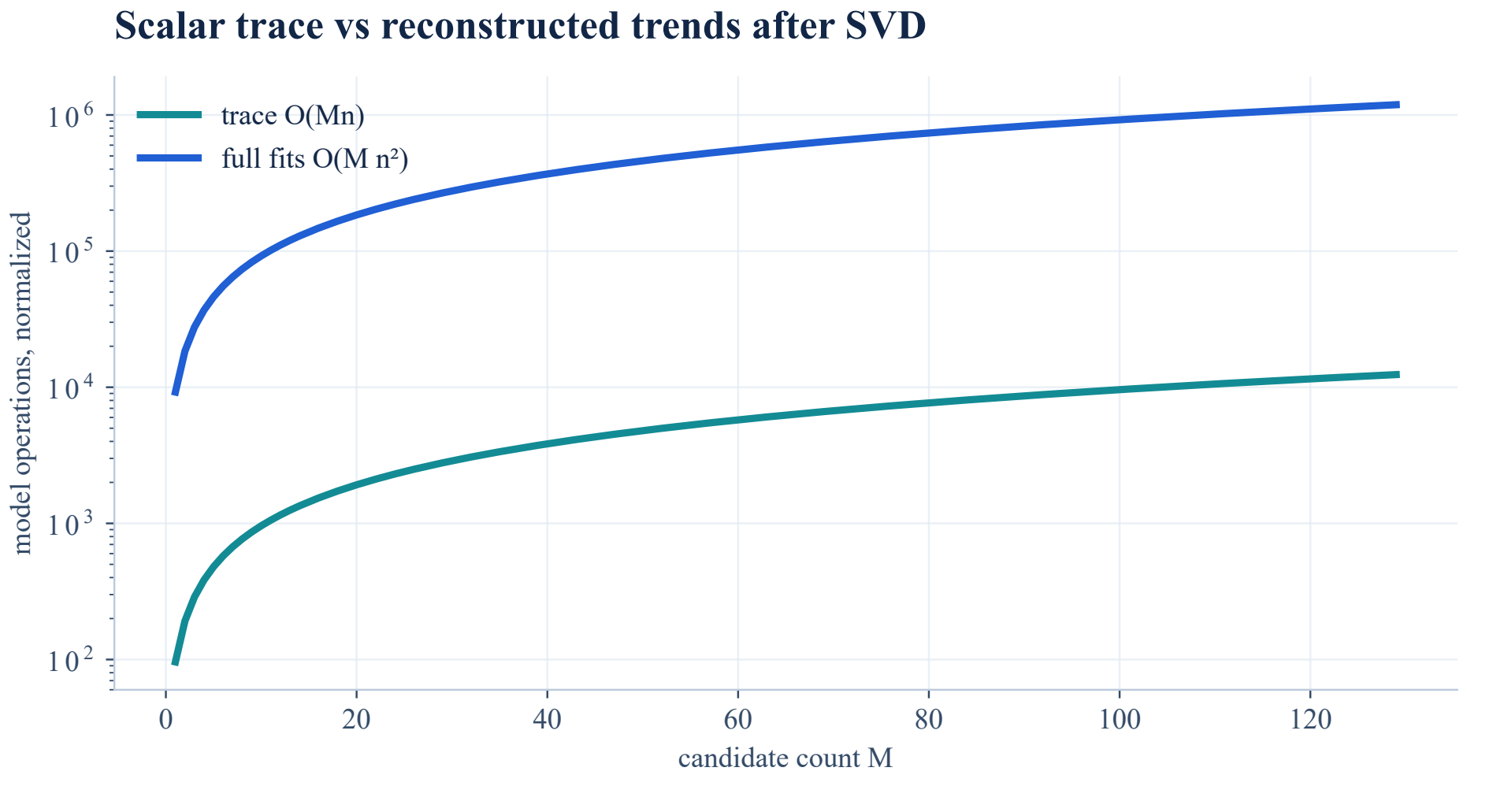
For positive-mode coordinates c_j and attenuation α_j:

$$\boxed{\nu(\lambda) = d + \sum_{j=1}^{n-d} \alpha_j(\lambda).}$$

$$\boxed{\mathrm{RSS}(\lambda) = \sum_{j=1}^{n-d} (1 - \alpha_j(\lambda))^2 c_j^2.}$$

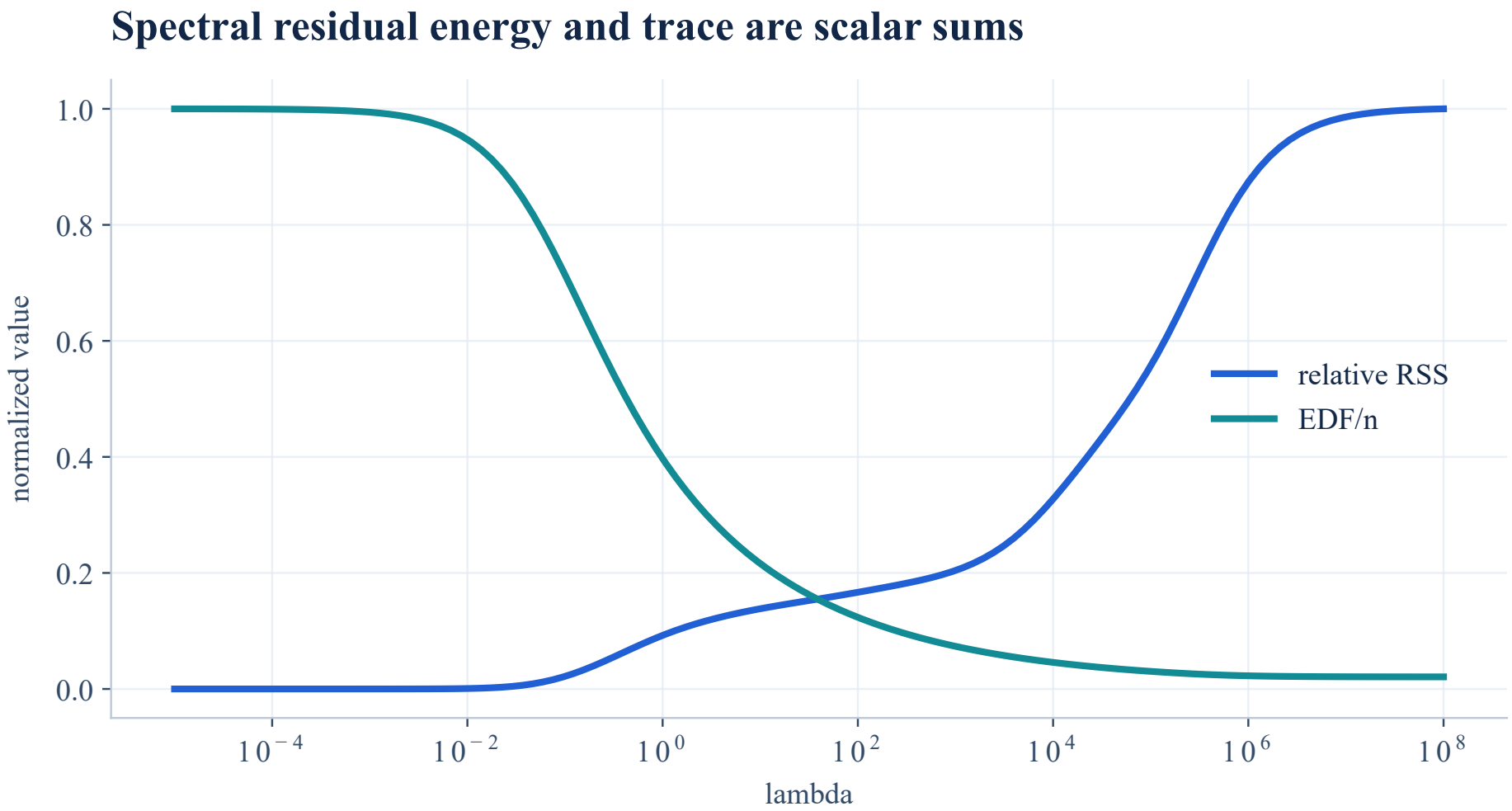
These are the inputs for effective degrees of freedom and several classical scalar scores.

Full fitted curves are not scalar trace queries



Illustrative arithmetic growth, not measured benchmark times.

Trace and residual energy as scalar spectral summaries



The functions are computed from a reused spectral basis.

V. Effective degrees of freedom

A trace-based interpretation of smoothing intensity

What are effective degrees of freedom?

For fixed numerical μ,

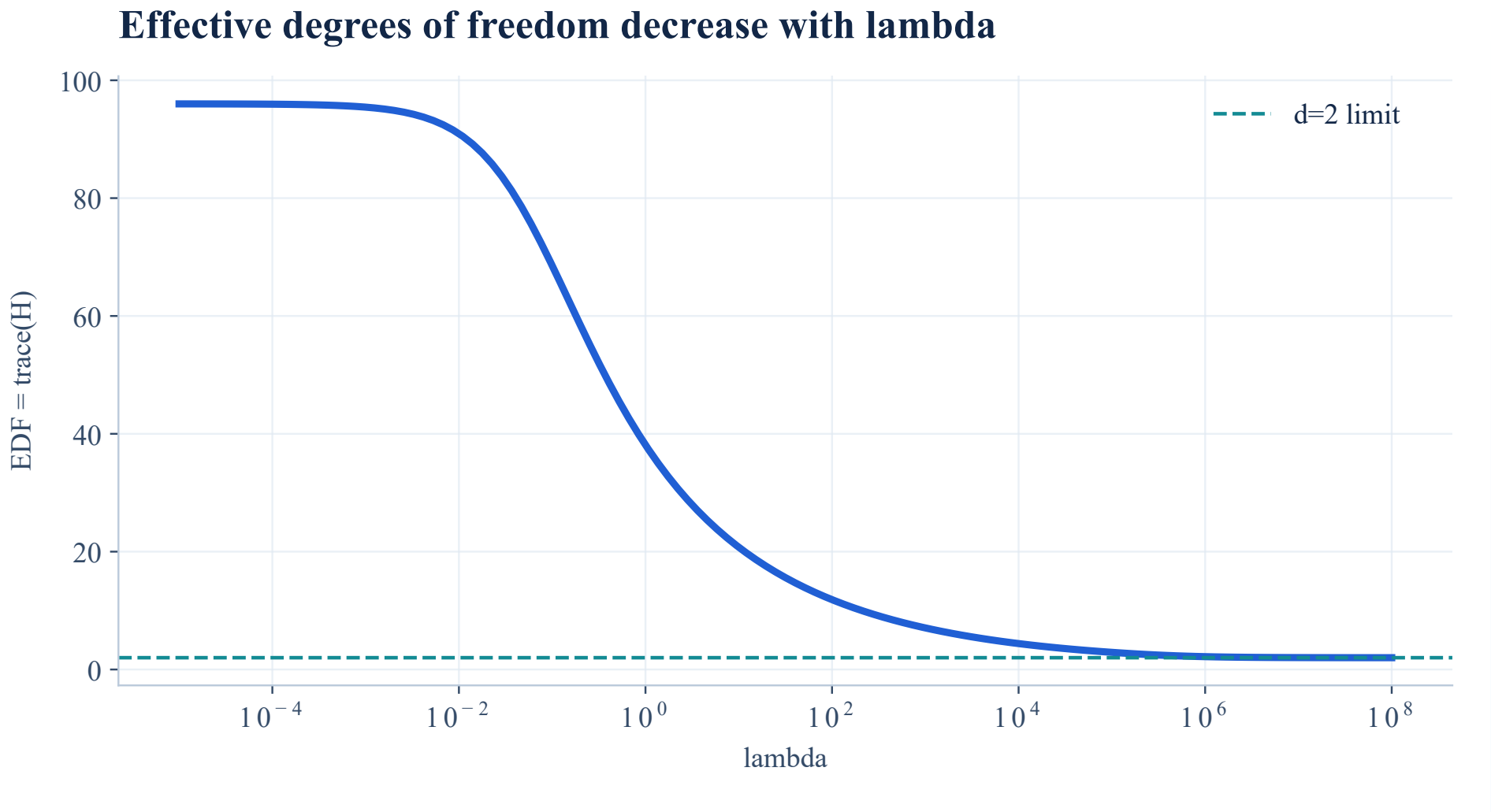
$$\nu(\lambda) = \operatorname{tr}(H_\lambda) = d + \sum_{j=1}^{n-d} \frac{1}{1+\lambda\delta_j}.$$

With $d \geq 1$, $\nu(0) = n$ and $\nu(\infty) = d$.

For $d = 0$, the limiting EDF is zero.

A data-estimated μ alters the full fitted-value sensitivity.

EDF falls with the penalty



The infinite-penalty EDF equals d, the unpenalized dimension.

Guerrero's original smoothness index

$$\boxed{S_G(\lambda) = 1 - \frac{\nu(\lambda)}{n}.}$$

For order $d > 0$, its range is

$$0 \leq S_G(\lambda) \leq \frac{n-d}{n}.$$

Therefore the original denominator-n index **does not reach one** in general.

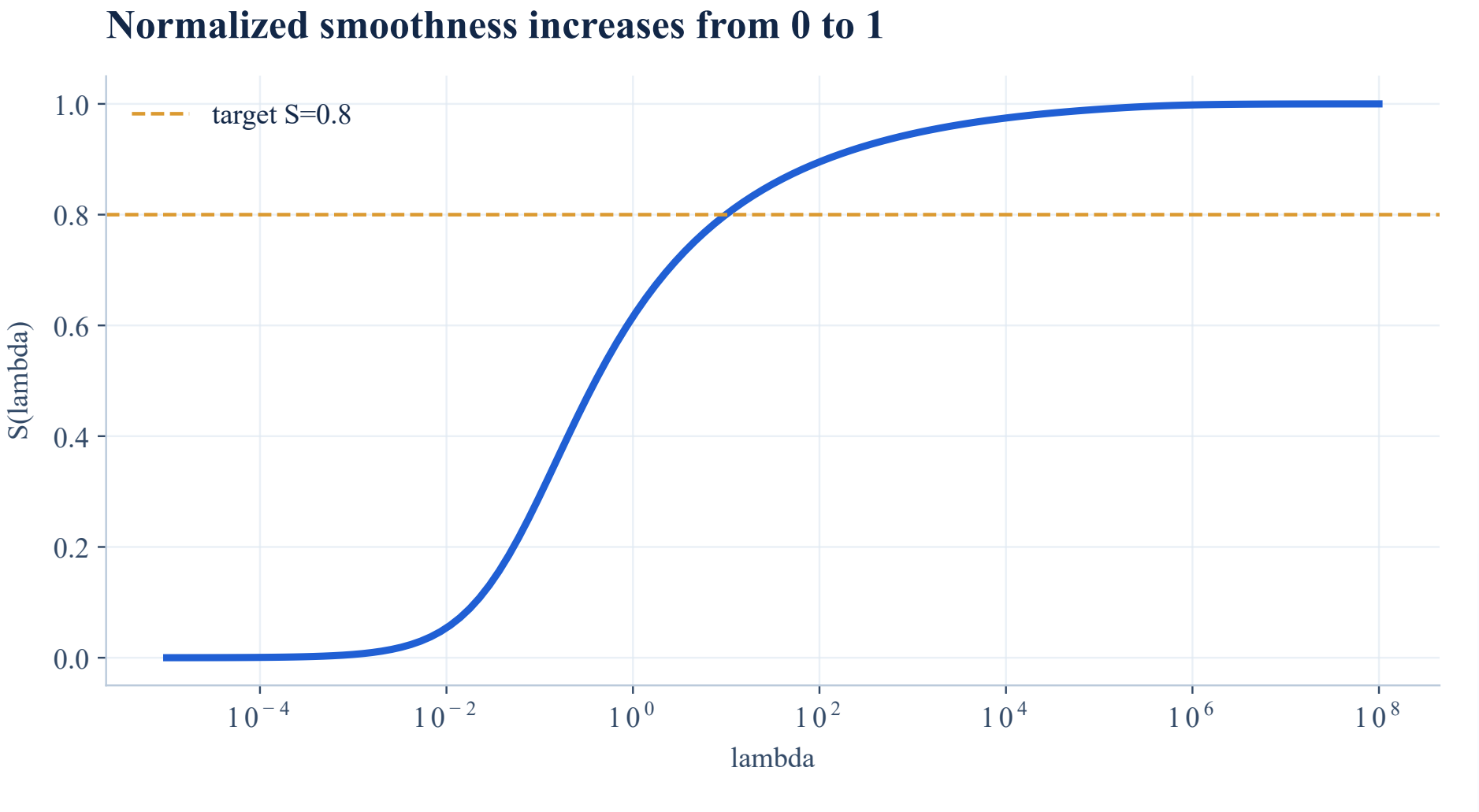
Our normalized smoothness coordinate

$$S(\lambda) = \frac{n - \nu(\lambda)}{n - d} = \frac{1}{n - d} \sum_{j=1}^{n-d} \frac{\lambda \delta_j}{1 + \lambda \delta_j}.$$

Now $S(0) = 0$ and $S(\infty) = 1$.

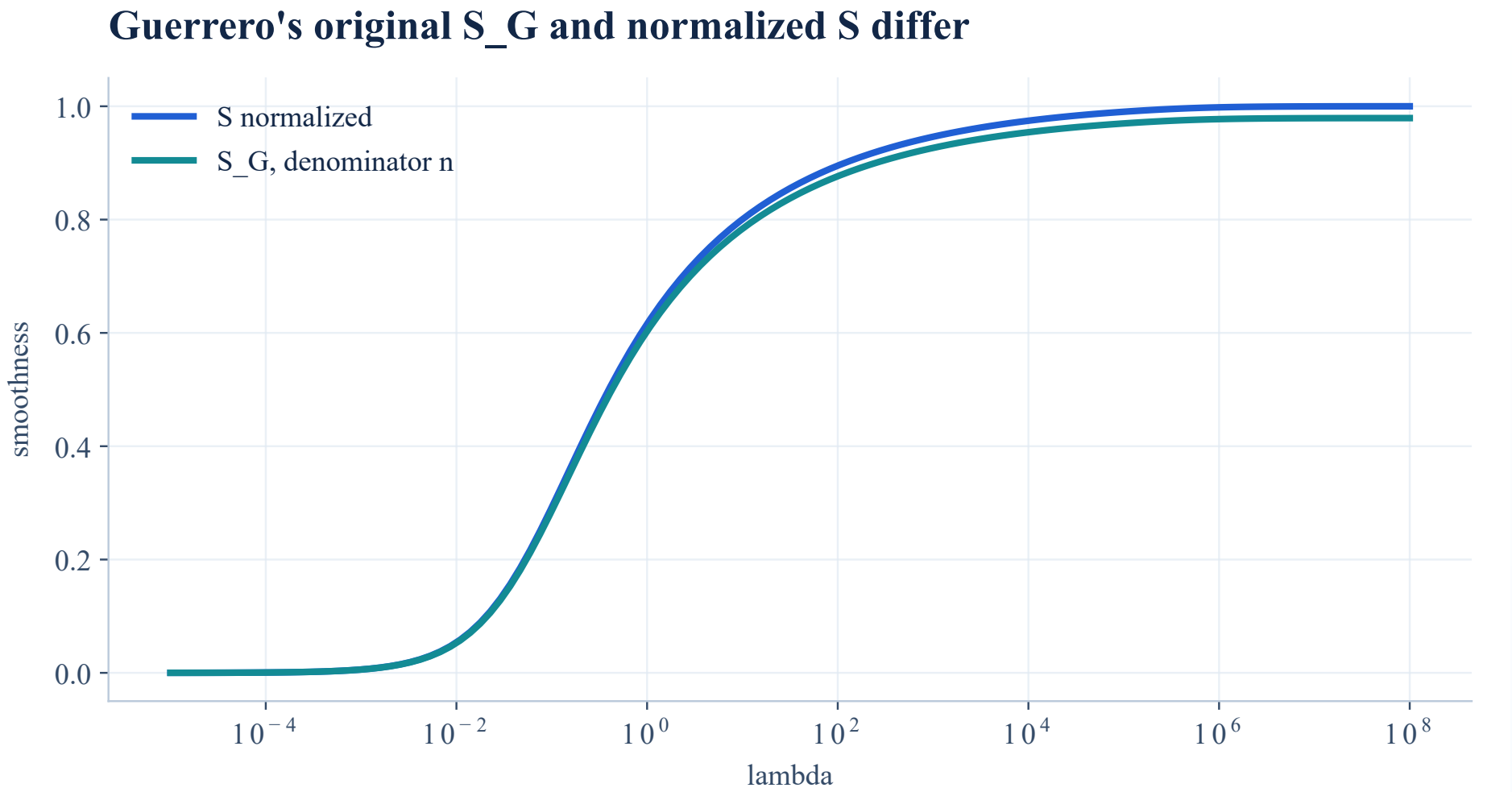
Meaning: average spectral shrinkage in the penalized directions.
Not: confidence, probability of correctness, or forecast accuracy.

A monotone index with exact endpoints



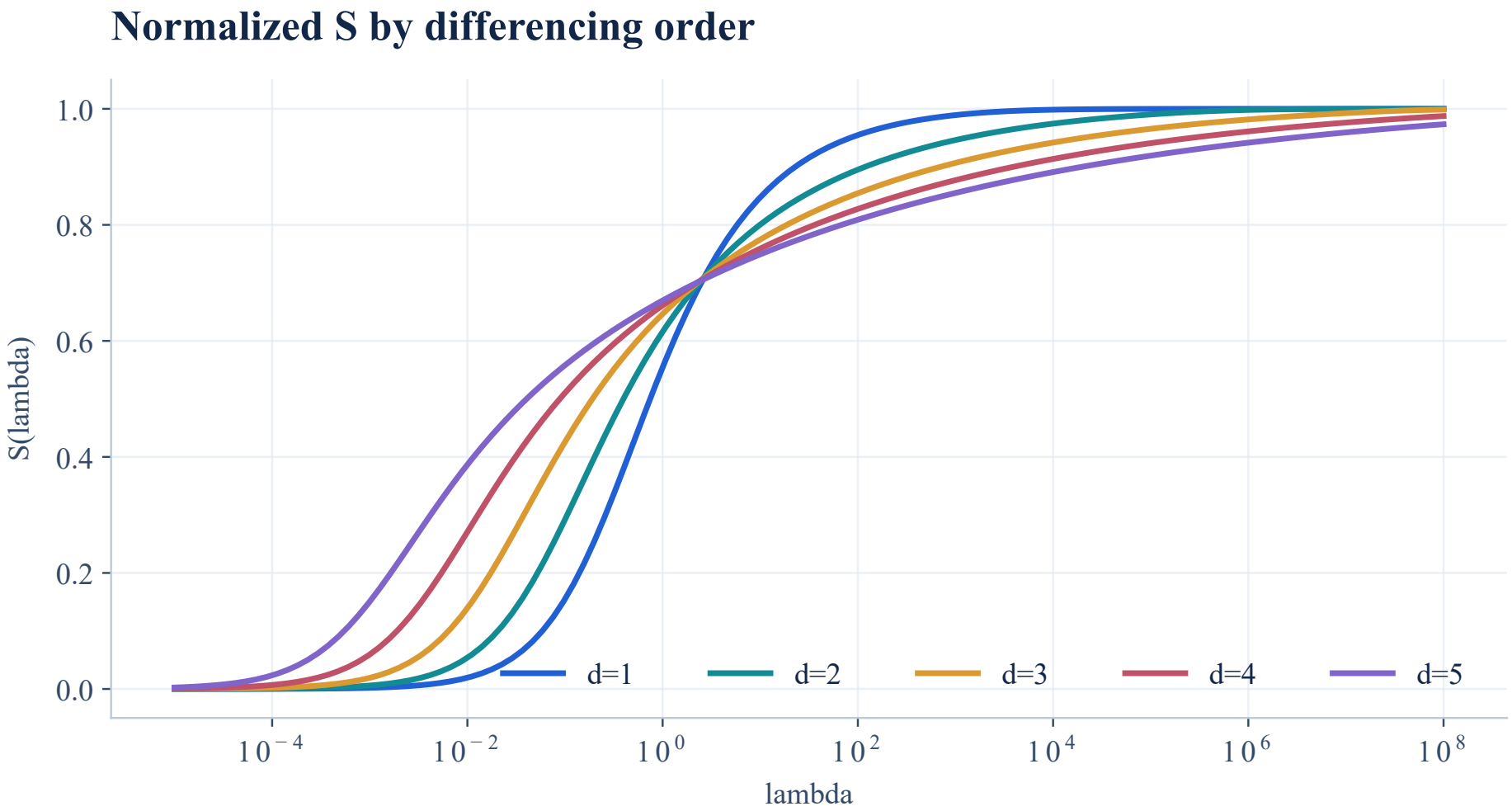
S ranges from zero to one.

Original Guerrero smoothness versus normalized smoothness



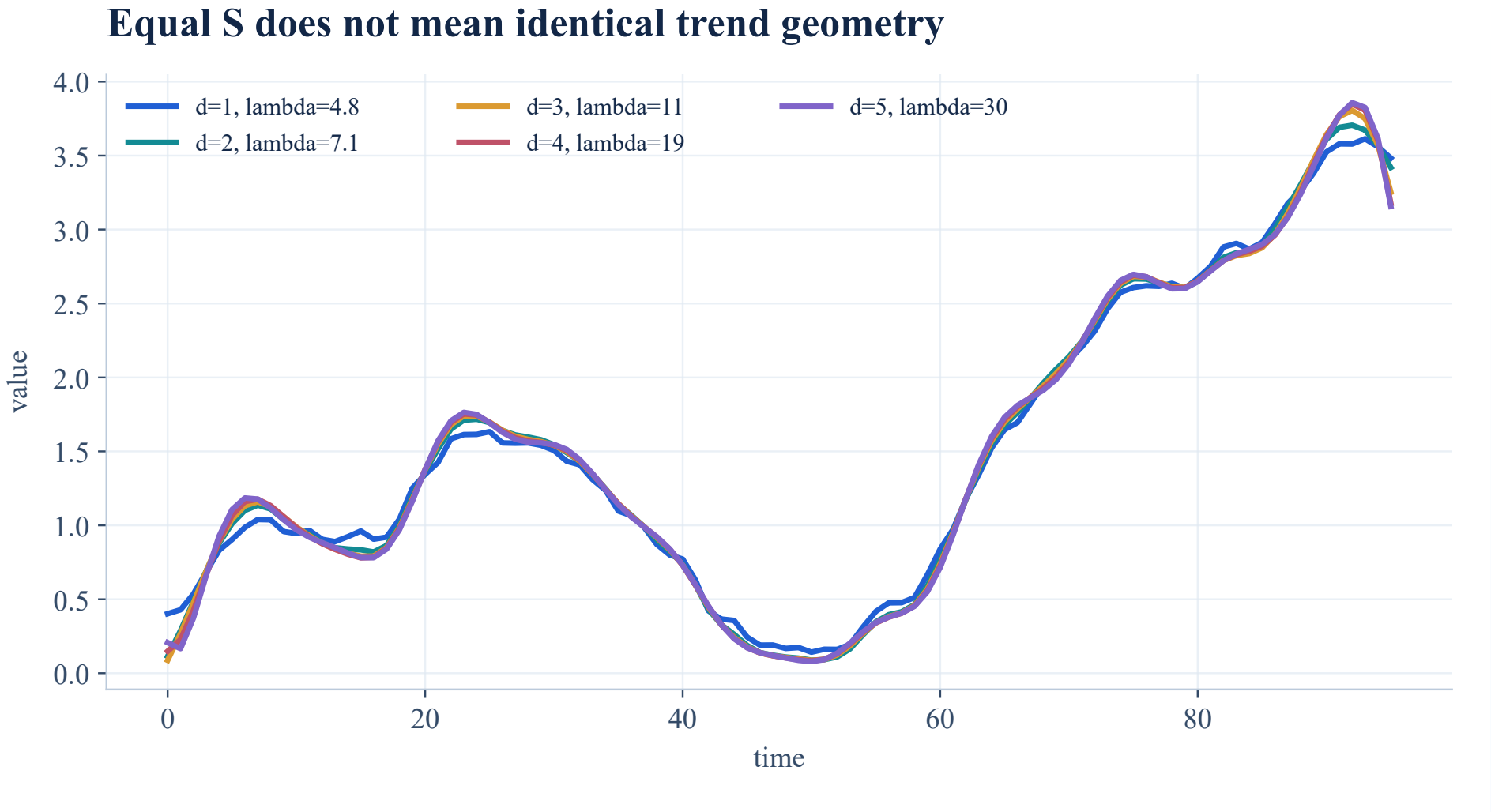
S_G=(n-d)S/n; the distinction matters when d>0.

Different d values induce different lambda-to-S maps



Equal numerical penalties can yield very different shrinkage.

Equal S does not make geometries identical



A common trace index does not imply identical fits across orders.

Prove the monotone inverse exists

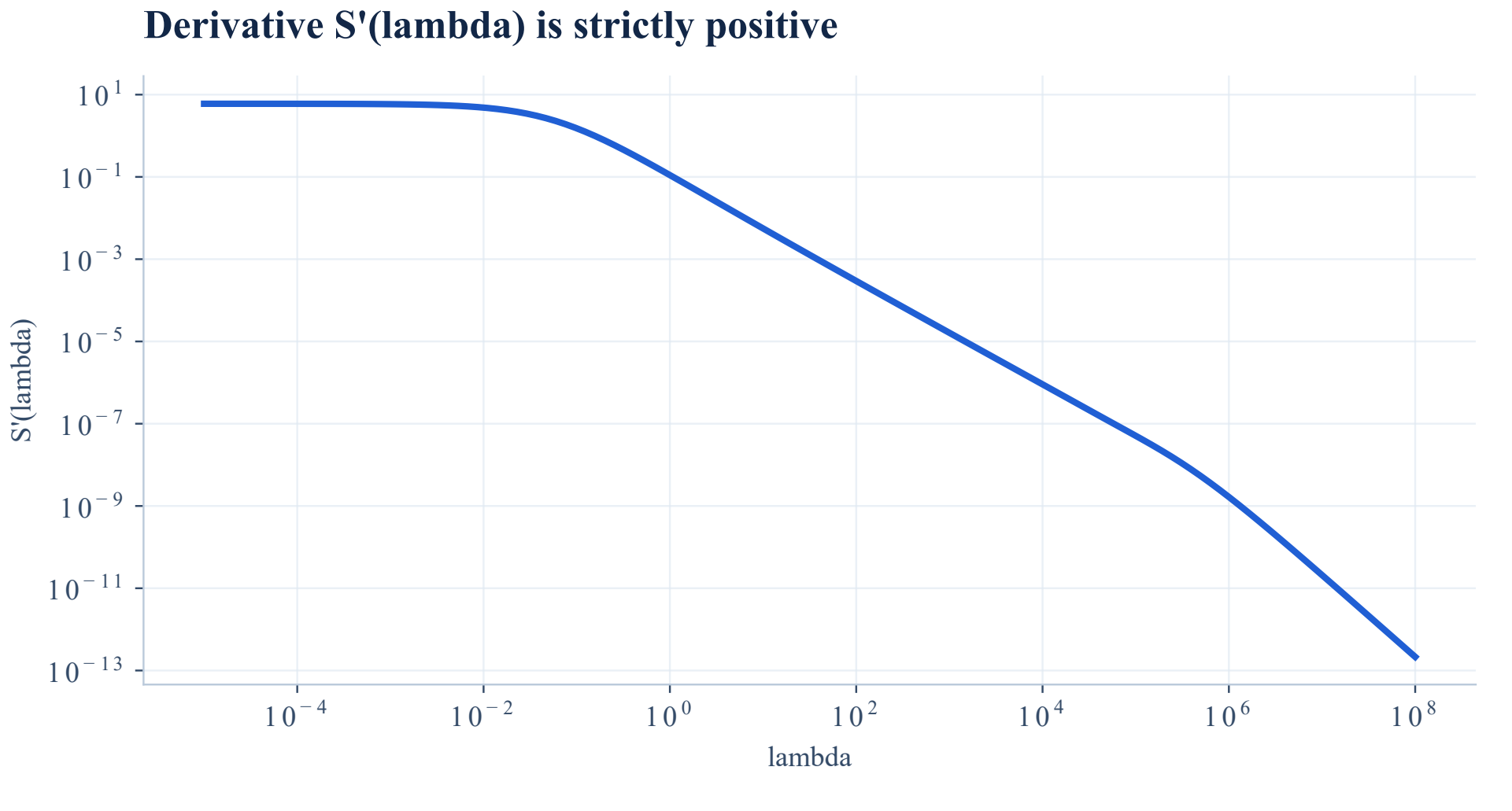
For every finite $\lambda \geq 0$,

$$\boxed{S'(\lambda) = \frac{1}{n-d} \sum_{j=1}^{n-d} \frac{\delta_j}{(1+\lambda\delta_j)^2} > 0.}$$

Every summand is positive on the resolved positive spectrum, so S is strictly increasing and continuous.

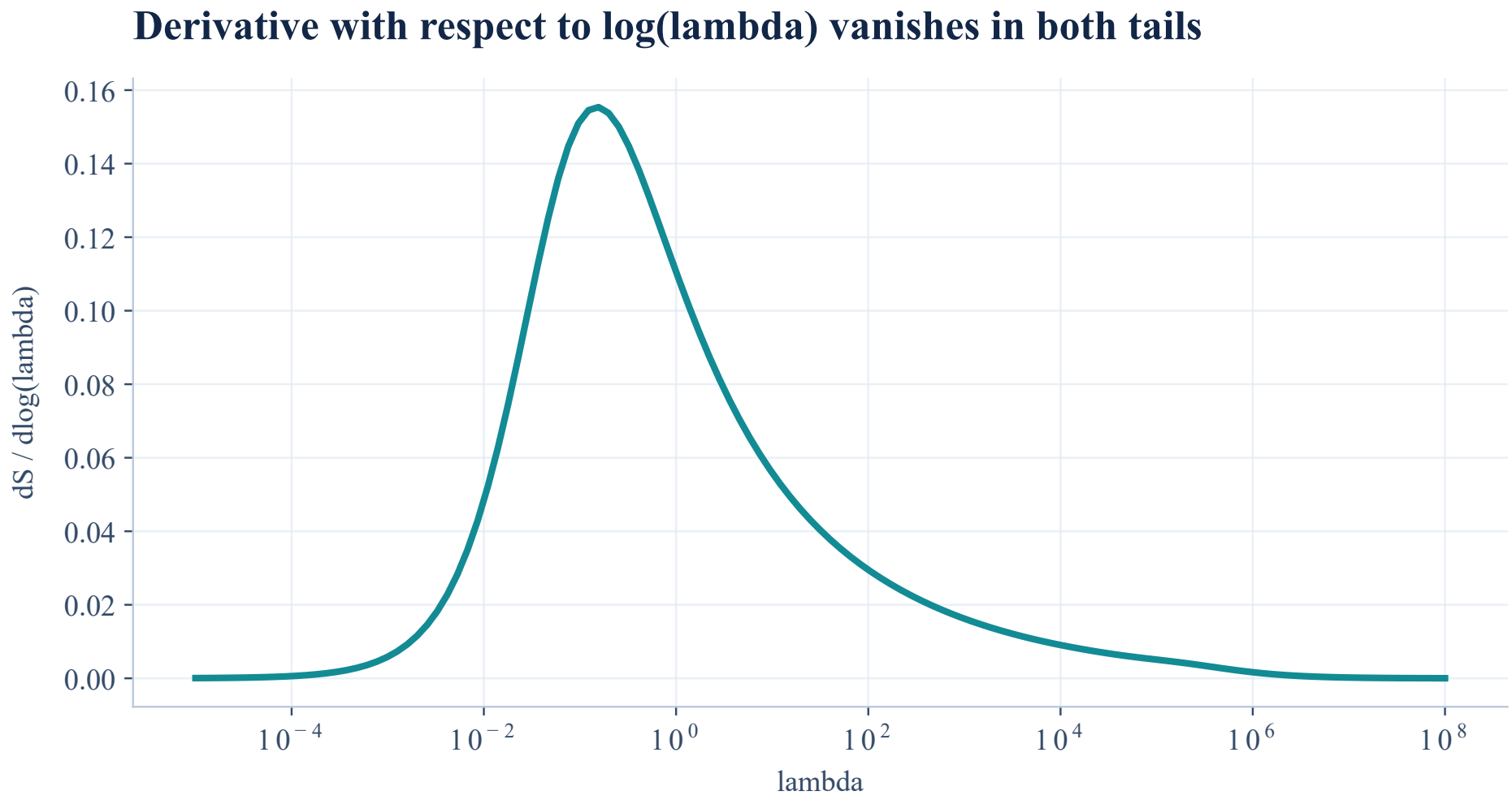
Define $\Lambda(s) = S^{-1}(s)$ on $0 < s < 1$ and extend with $\Lambda(0) = 0$, $\Lambda(1) = \infty$.

The first derivative remains positive



The derivative is positive but becomes small for very large lambda.

Derivative with respect to log(lambda)



Small slopes near both extremes matter for optimization conditioning.

VI. Select lambda or select S

A bounded coordinate for the same statistical problem

Reparameterize a criterion without changing it

Let $C(\lambda;\mu)$ denote an existing criterion evaluated at fixed μ.

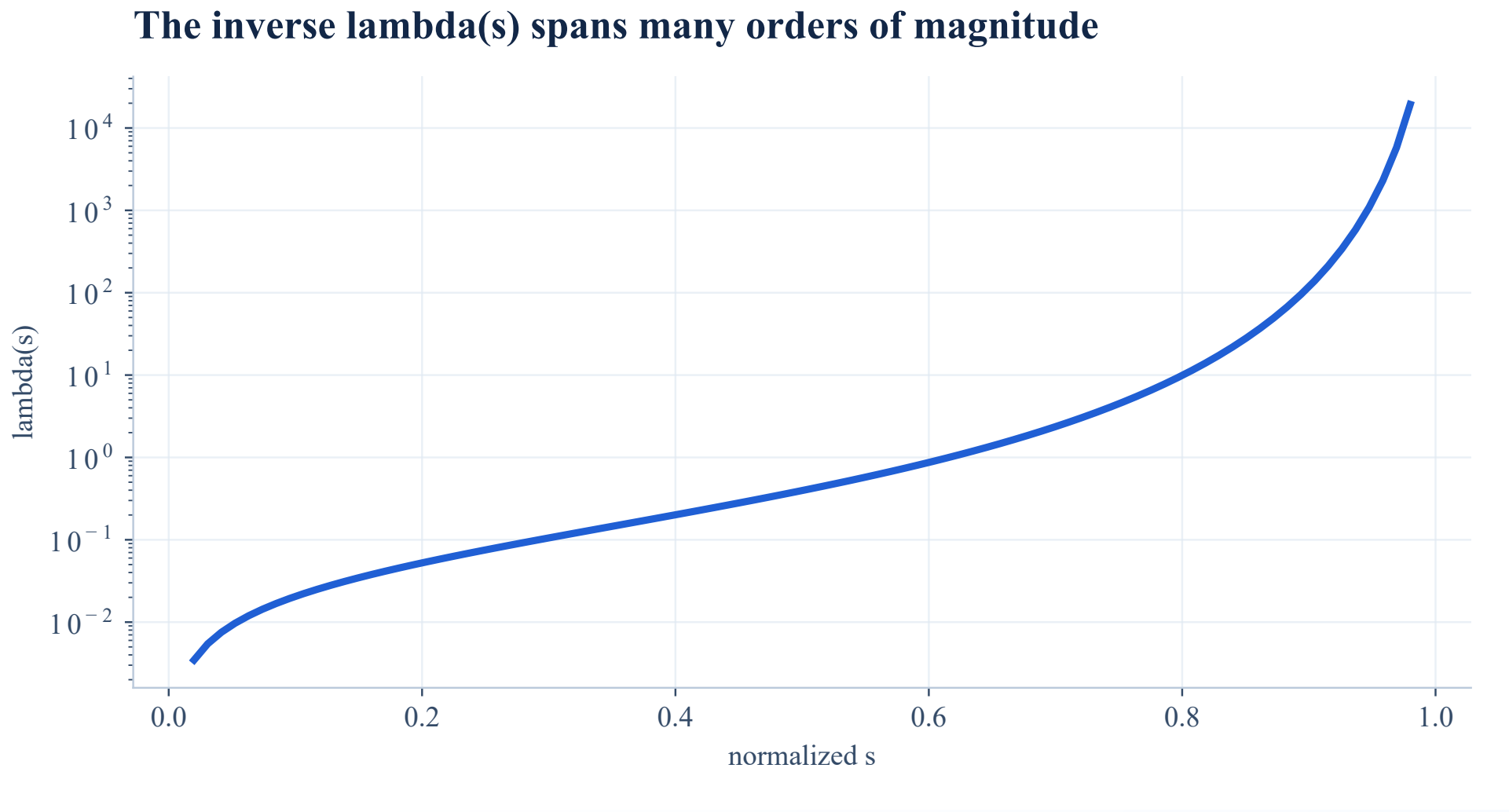
Write $\Lambda = S^{-1}$ and $\widetilde{C}(s;\mu) = C(\Lambda(s);\mu)$.

$$\boxed{\hat{s} \in \arg\min_{s\in[0,1]} \widetilde{C}(s;\mu), \quad \widehat{\lambda} = \Lambda(\hat{s}).}$$

Exact global minimizers correspond under this monotone map (ties and undefined endpoints must be treated carefully).

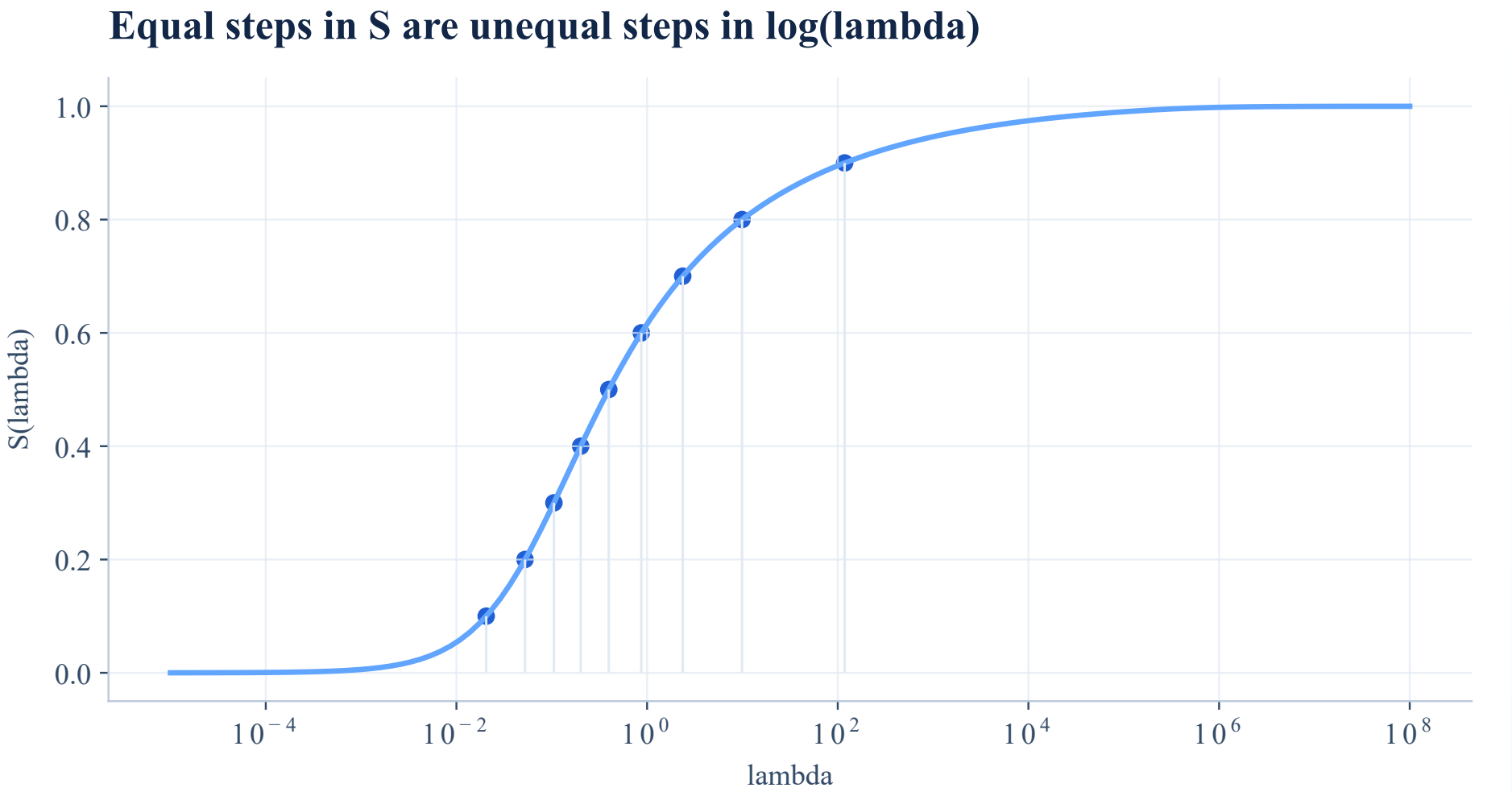
This is **not a newly invented selection criterion**.

Inverse smoothness: bounded S, unbounded penalty



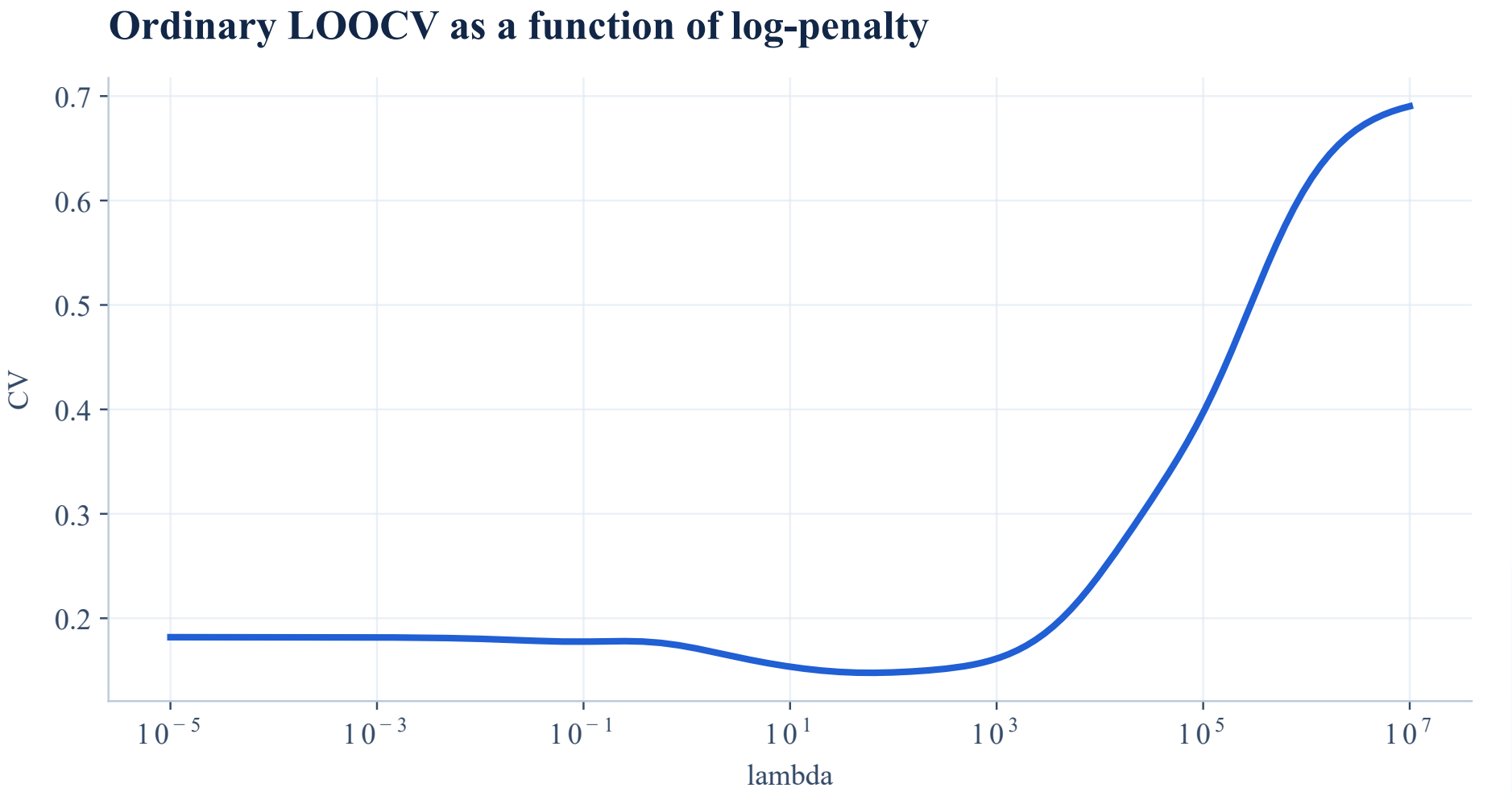
The numerical inverse may cover many orders of magnitude.

Equal steps in S are uneven in lambda



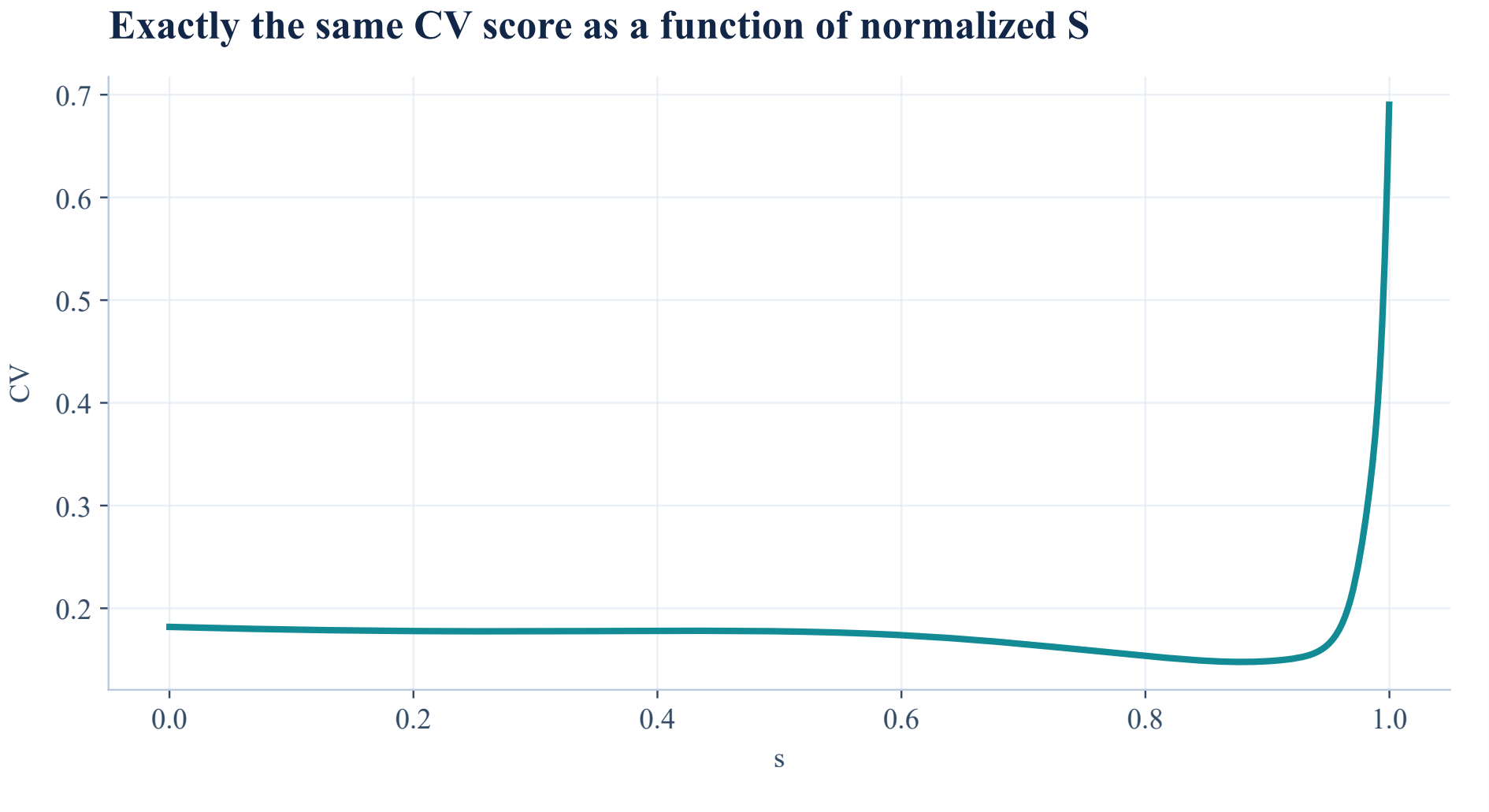
A uniform S grid and a log-lambda grid are not the same candidate set.

The CV objective on the penalty scale



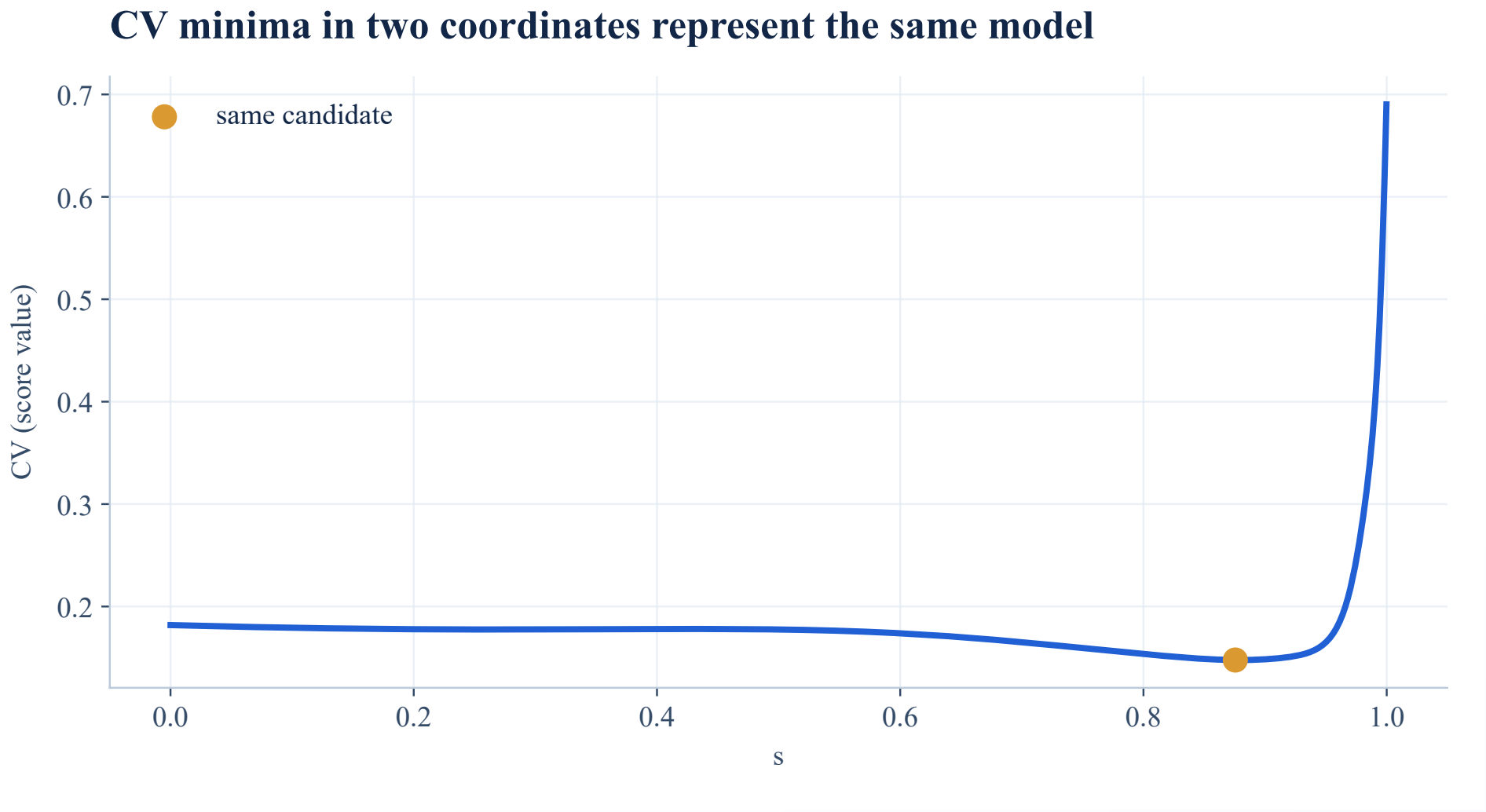
Ordinary fixed-mu LOOCV score as a function of lambda.

The SAME CV score in the smoothness coordinate



The statistical score has not been modified.

The optimum corresponds under S and lambda



Finite candidate grids may still find different local minima.

The chain rule gives the exact derivative

Since $s = S(\lambda)$ and $S' > 0$,

$$\frac{d\lambda}{ds} = \frac{1}{S'(\lambda)}.$$

Therefore,

$$\boxed{\frac{d\widetilde{C}}{ds} = \frac{C'(\lambda)}{S'(\lambda)} = \frac{dC/d\log\lambda}{dS/d\log\lambda}.}$$

Interior derivative zeros occur at the same fitted trends.
Near S=0 or S=1 the denominator can be tiny.

The stable log-penalty derivative of S

$$\frac{dS}{d\log\lambda} = \frac{1}{n-d}\sum_{j=1}^{n-d}\frac{\lambda\delta_j}{(1+\lambda\delta_j)^2} > 0.$$

Classical CV already has an analytical derivative in the library.

For S-based CV search, evaluate the chain-rule quotient and compare multiple stationary candidates and exact boundaries.

Neither numerical search is globally certified.

What the public selector supports

Argument	Meaning
search_space="lambda"	Original default, search penalties
search_space="smoothness"	Search normalized S in [0,1]
criterion="cv", method="auto"	Analytical multi-candidate derivative search
GCV/AICc/BIC/MLE, method="auto"	Grid search in chosen coordinate
Explicit grid	Interpreted in chosen coordinate
Result grid	Always the evaluated lambda values
Result search_grid	Values in requested search coordinate

Try both coordinates in Python

```
from trendestimation import TrendSmoother, select_lambda
solver = TrendSmoother(len(y), order=2)

default = select_lambda(
    solver, y, criterion="cv", mu=0.0,
    search_space="lambda",
)
bounded = select_lambda(
    solver, y, criterion="cv", mu=0.0,
    search_space="smoothness",
)

print(default.lambda_, default.smoothness)
print(bounded.lambda_, bounded.smoothness)
```

Explicit grid of normalized smoothness levels

```
selected = select_lambda(
    solver, y, criterion="gcv", mu=0.0,
    search_space="smoothness",
    grid=[0, .25, .50, .75, 1],
)

selected.lambda_       # fitted penalty
selected.smoothness    # achieved normalized index
selected.grid          # evaluated penalties
selected.search_grid   # input S coordinates
selected.scores        # unchanged criterion values
```

Why a bounded interval is not automatically faster

- Each interior S requires solving S(lambda)=s.
- Several scalar spectral evaluations can be needed per inverse.
- The chain-rule derivative can become sensitive in the tails.
- Uniform S and log-lambda grids cover **different finite candidates**.
- More optimizer evaluations can erase the advantages of an interpretable coordinate.

No actual end-to-end runtime improvement has been established for optimizing over S.

VII. Statistical selection criteria

What gets minimized and how its derivative arises

Ordinary leave-one-out CV

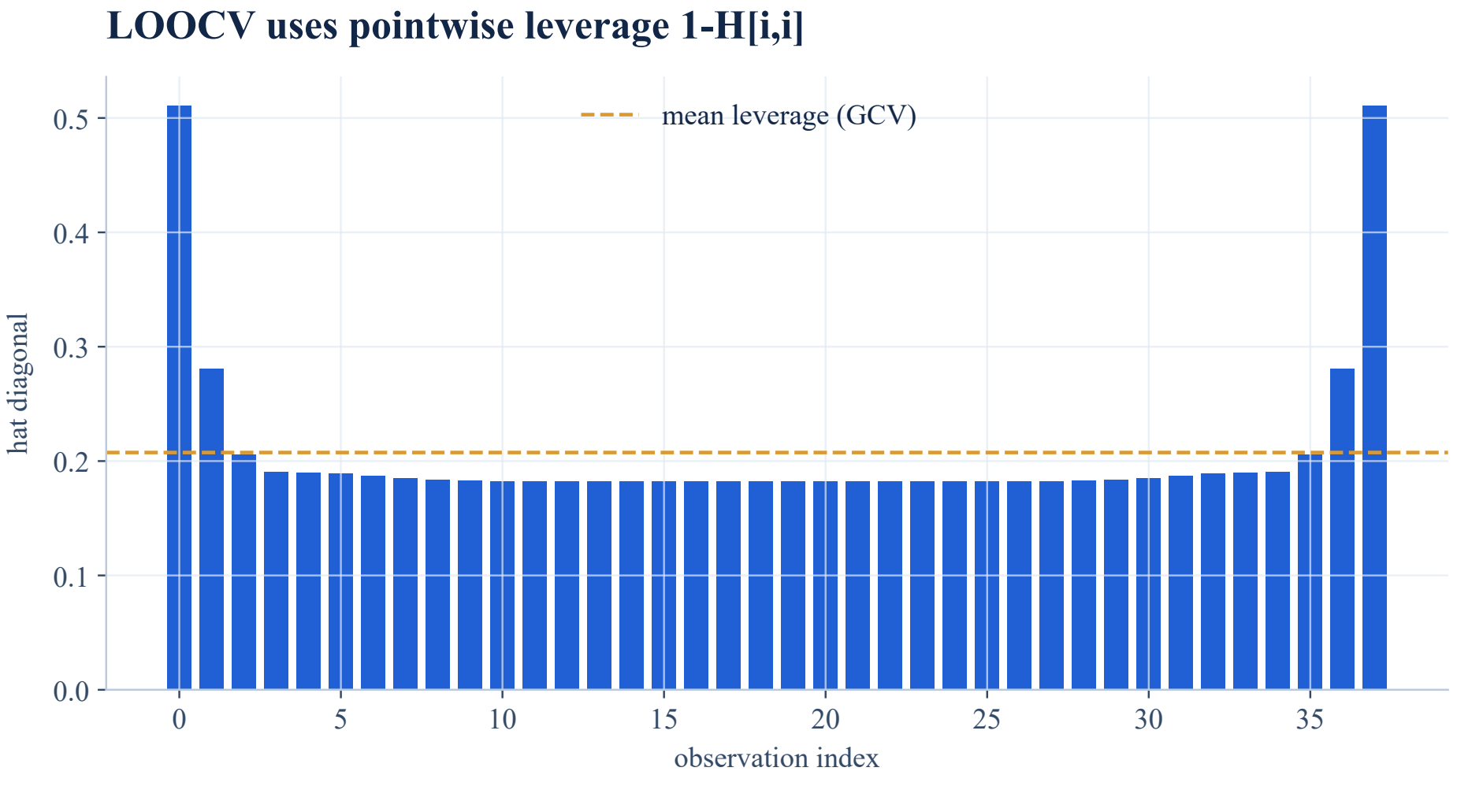
Let $e = y - \widehat{\tau}$, $h_{ii} = (H_\lambda)_{ii}$ with **fixed numeric** μ.

$$\boxed{\mathrm{CV}(\lambda) = \frac{1}{n} \sum_i \left(\frac{e_i}{1 - h_{ii}} \right)^2 .}$$

At lambda=0, $H = I$ and the shortcut has zero denominators.

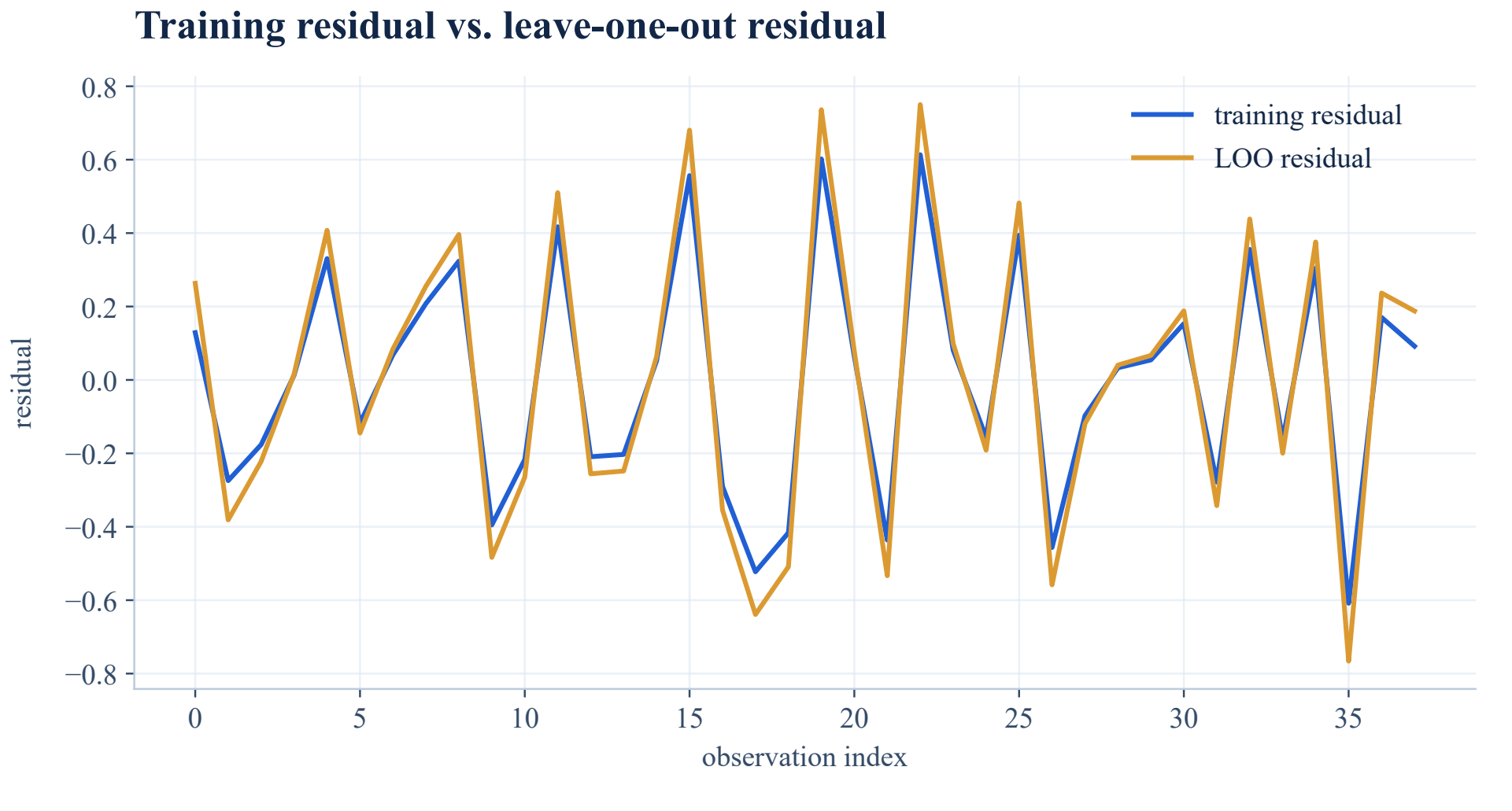
This is **not chronological or rolling-origin forecast validation**.

The leverage of each observation



GCV replaces individual leverages by their mean.

Training residuals vs leave-one-out residuals



e_i^(-i)=e_i/(1-h_ii), provided mu and the penalty are fixed.

Analytical derivative of classical CV

Set $a_i = e_i$ and $b_i = 1 - h_{ii}$. From $H' = -HQH$,

$$a' = HQH(y - p), \qquad b_i' = (HQH)_{ii}.$$

Then

$$\boxed{\mathrm{CV}'(\lambda) = \frac{2}{n} \sum_i \frac{a_i}{b_i} \frac{a_i' b_i - a_i b_i'}{b_i^2}.}$$

This is an analytical derivative, not a closed-form optimal lambda.

GCV, AICc, BIC: implemented conventions

With $R = \mathrm{RSS}$ and $\nu = \mathrm{tr}(H_\lambda)$:

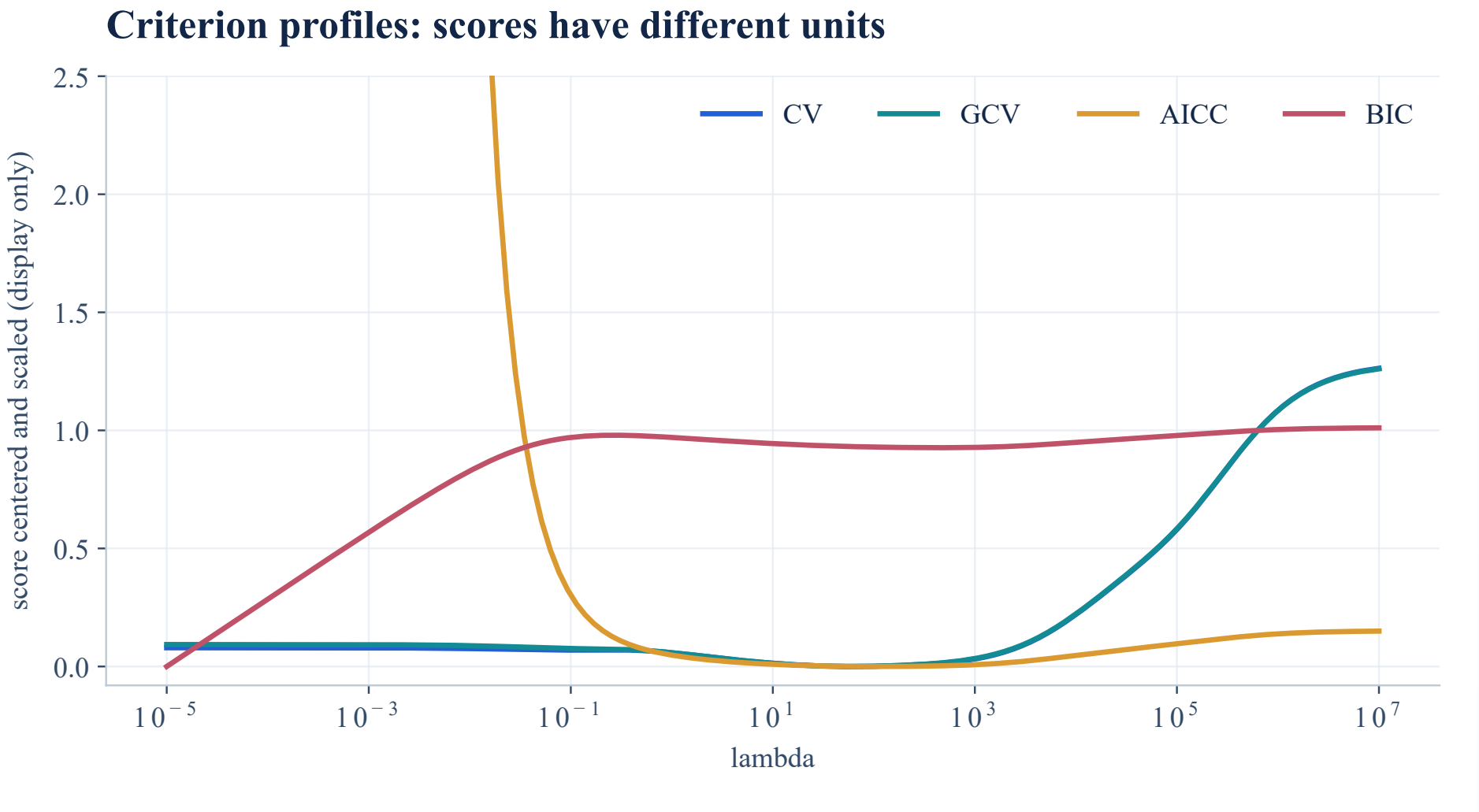
$$\boxed{\mathrm{GCV} = \frac{R/n}{(1-\nu/n)^2}.}$$

$$\boxed{\mathrm{AICc} = \log(R/n) + \frac{2\nu+1}{n-\nu-2}.}$$

$$\boxed{\mathrm{BIC} = \log(R/n) + \frac{\nu \log n}{n}.}$$

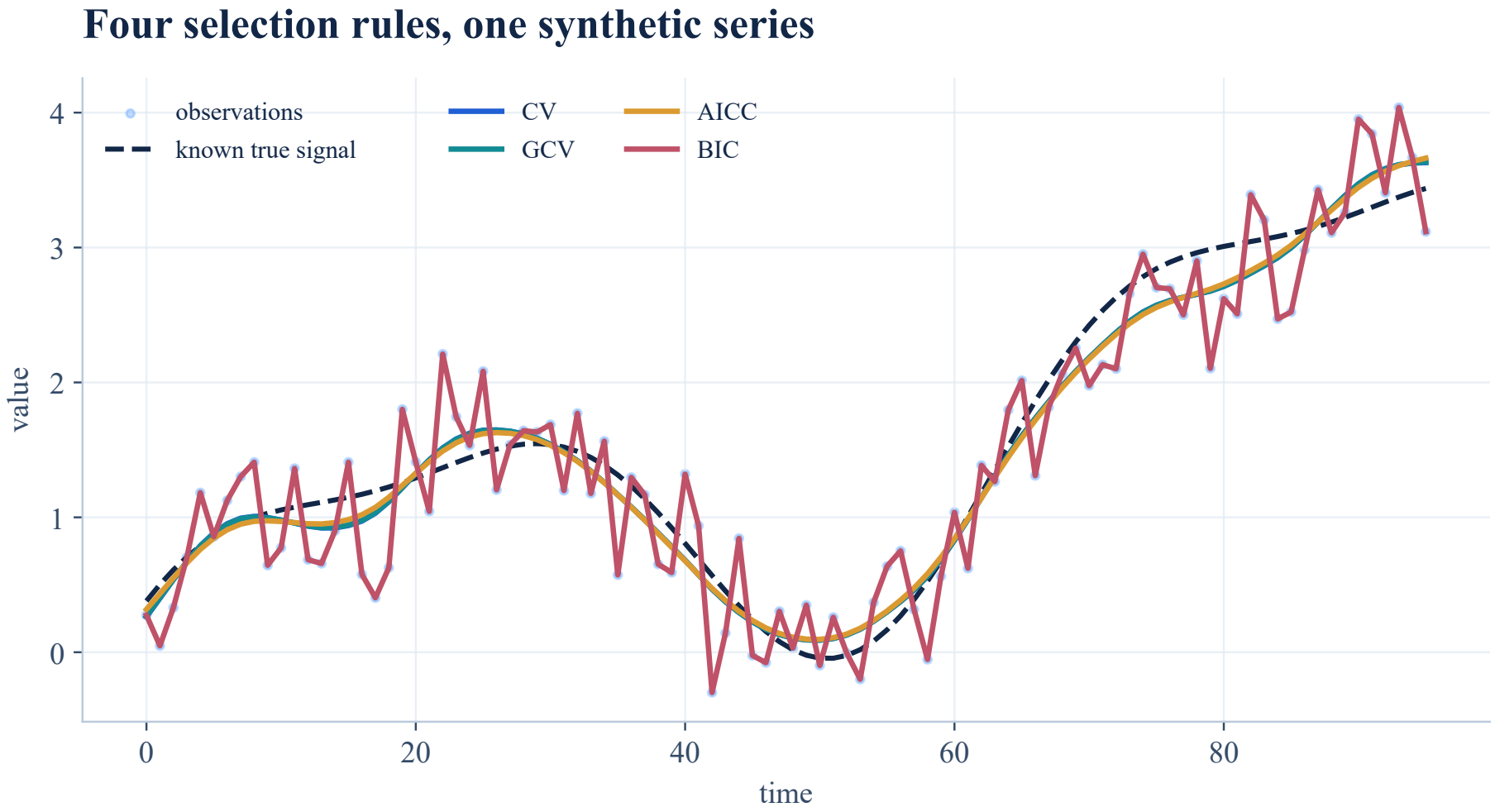
Admissible domains matter; AICc conventions vary across the literature.

All four scores as functions of lambda



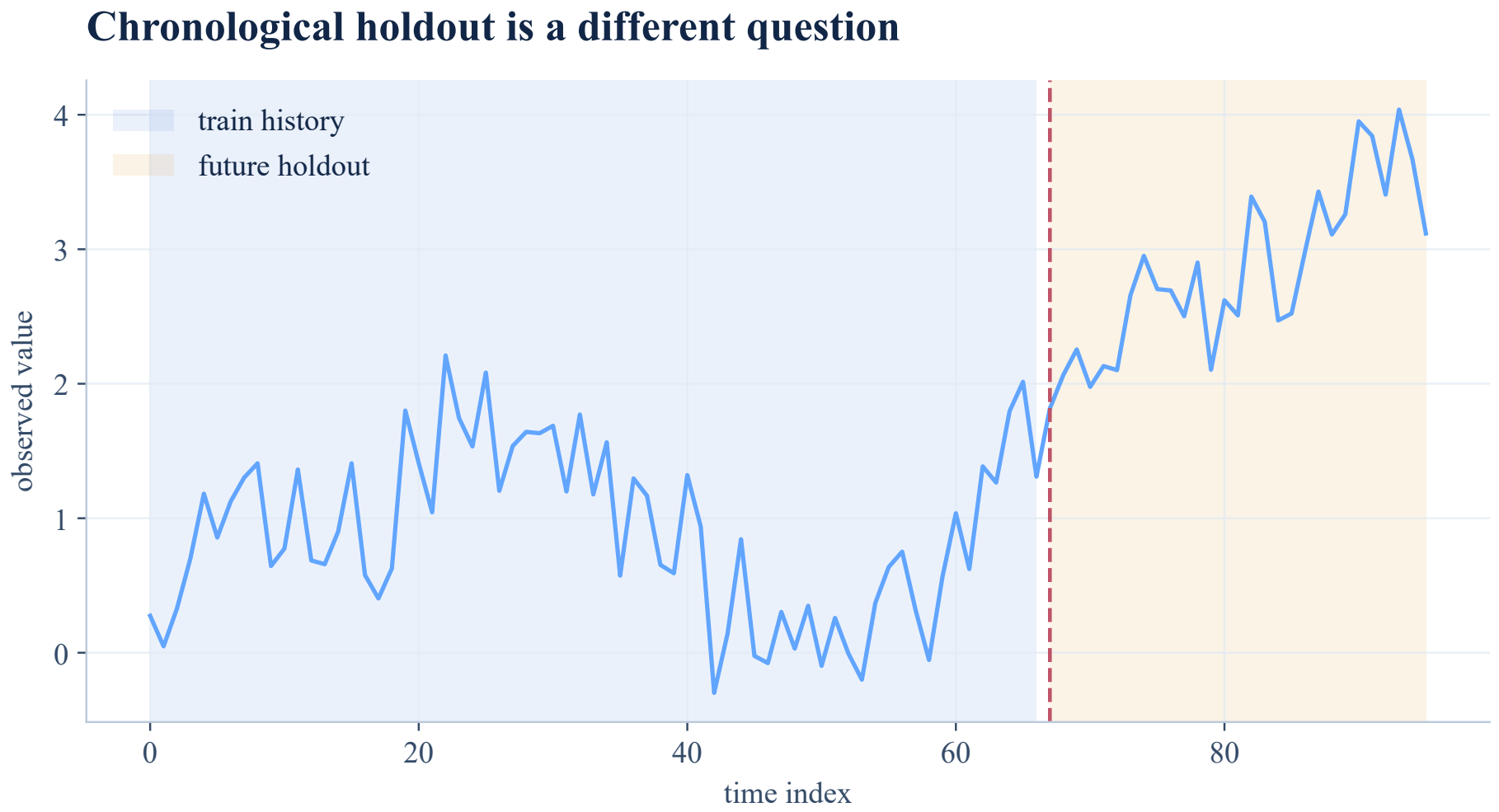
Profiles centered and rescaled only for the plot. Real selection uses original units.

Different criteria yield different in-sample trends



A single seeded example does not establish an overall ranking.

LOOCV versus chronological holdout



Future-horizon forecasting requires a different experimental design.

VIII. Gaussian marginal likelihood

Conditional MLE is implemented; joint mu profiling is future work

The Gaussian stochastic model

$$y = \tau + \varepsilon, \qquad \varepsilon \sim N(0, \sigma_\varepsilon^2 I).$$

$$D_d \tau - \mu \mathbf{1} \sim N(0, \sigma_\eta^2 I), \qquad \boxed{\lambda = \frac{\sigma_\varepsilon^2}{\sigma_\eta^2}.}$$

This is a **model-based interpretation**, not a property of arbitrary distributions.

The unpenalized polynomial coordinates are treated as nuisance trend components.

Conditional Gaussian marginal likelihood

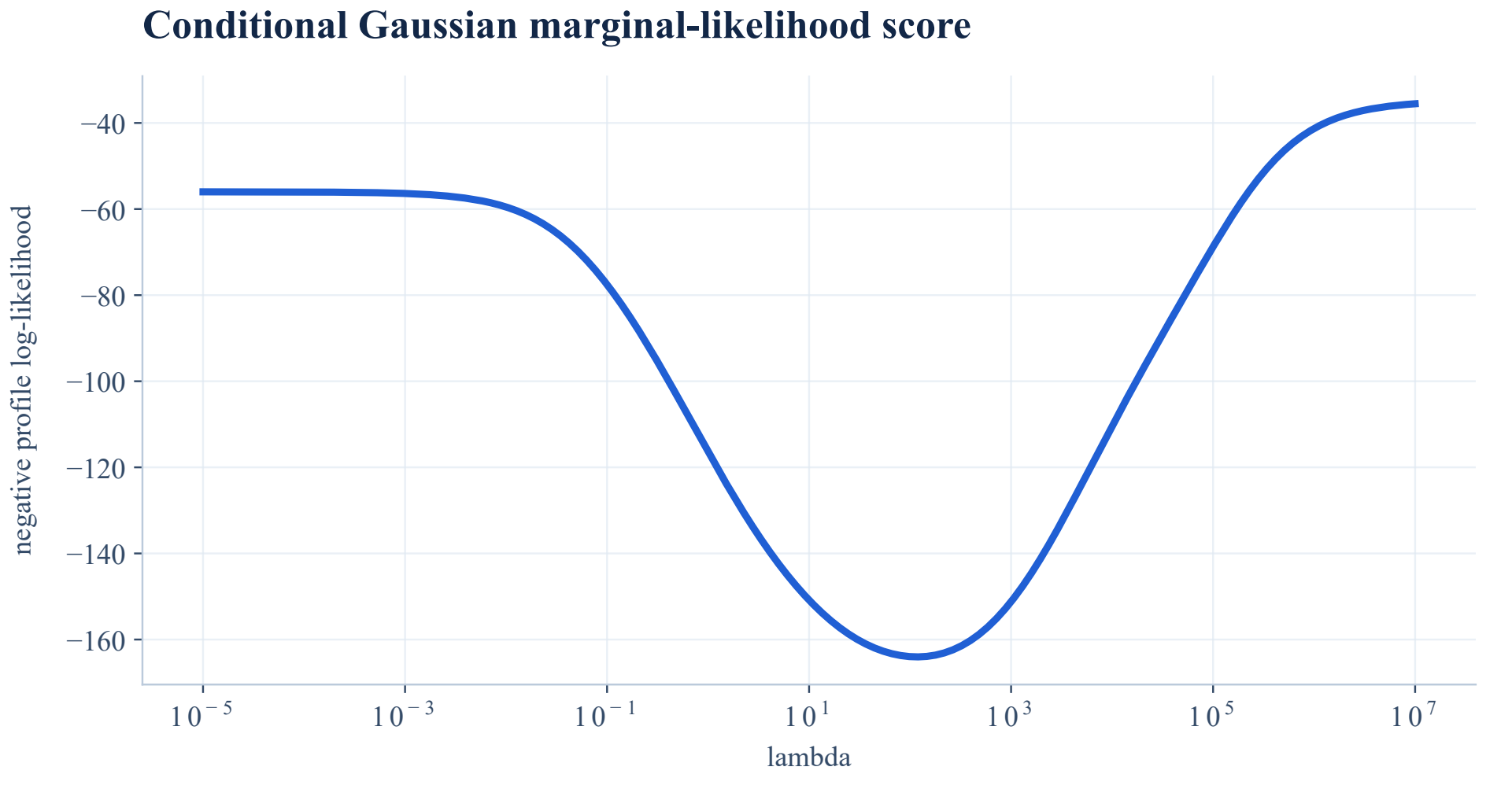
Set $r = n - d$, $w_j(\lambda) = \lambda\delta_j/(1+\lambda\delta_j)$ and $z_j = v_j^\top(y - p_\mu)$.

The profile score, up to constants, is

$$\boxed{L(\lambda;\mu) = r\log\left(\frac{1}{r}\sum_{j=1}^{r} w_j z_j^2\right) - \sum_{j=1}^{r}\log w_j.}$$

It profiles observation variance and selects λ for fixed or plug-in μ.

Conditional marginal-likelihood score



Gaussian model-based score, not cross-validation.

The analytical conditional likelihood mean

Let $p_t^{(1)} = \binom{t}{d}$, $z_j = v_j^\top y$ and $b_j = v_j^\top p^{(1)}$.

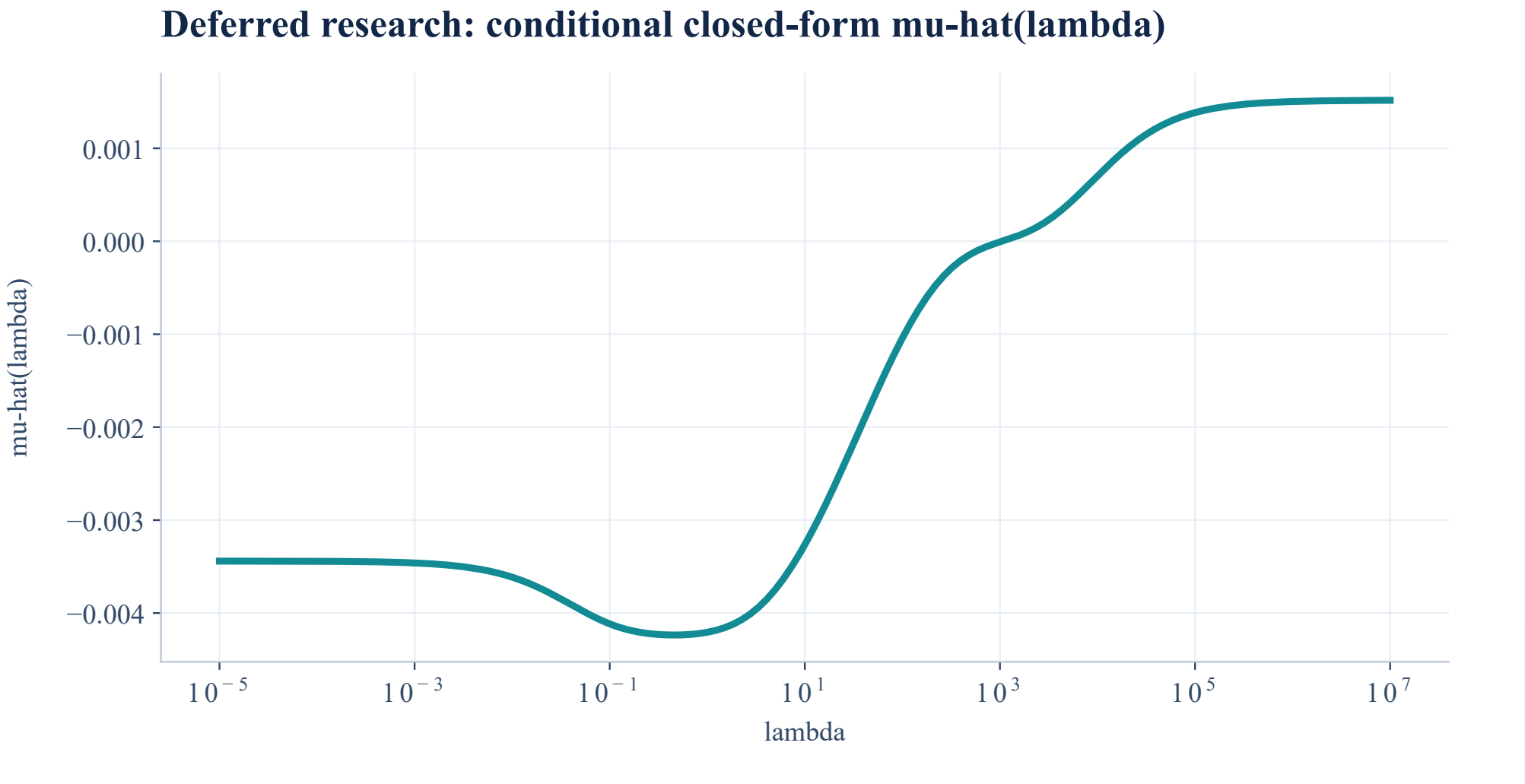
For fixed positive λ,

$$\boxed{\widehat{\mu}(\lambda) = \frac{\sum_j w_j(\lambda) b_j z_j}{\sum_j w_j(\lambda) b_j^2}.}$$

A nonzero denominator follows from the positive-subspace model assumptions.

This formula is retained as a deferred research result, not a validated joint API.

The optimal conditional mean can depend on lambda



Derived profile formula; no joint numerical optimizer is claimed.

A future scalar optimization of both lambda and mu

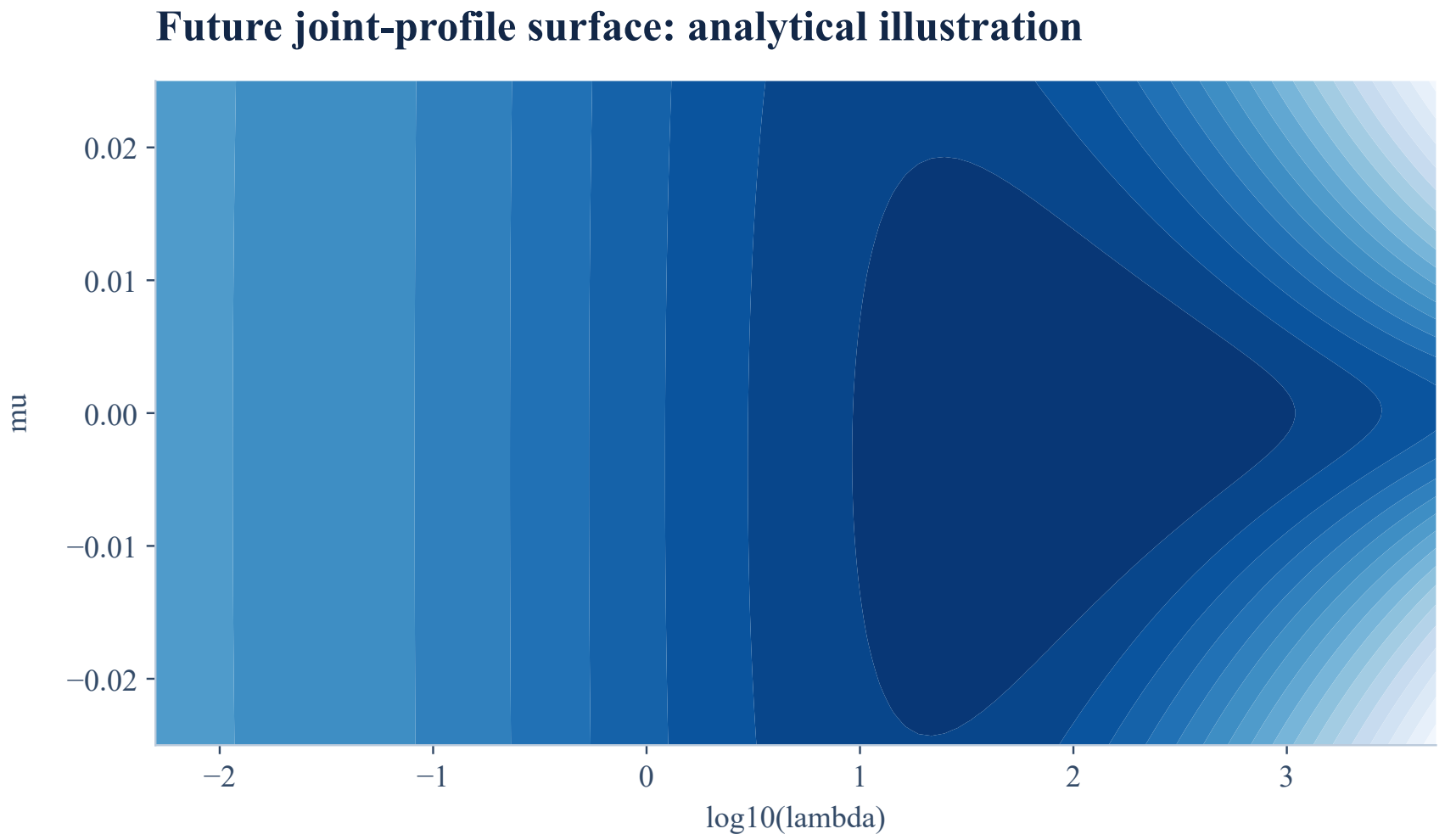
Rather than optimizing two variables numerically, insert the conditional optimum into the likelihood:

$$\boxed{\widehat{\lambda} = \arg\min_{\lambda>0} J(\lambda; \widehat{\mu}(\lambda)).}$$

Open problems: identifiability, boundary optima, numerical stability, inference and a fair comparison against conditional MLE.

This extension is not yet experimentally validated in the library.

Visualize the analytical joint-likelihood surface



Analytical schematic based on derived formula, not a released joint estimator.

Joint profiling could also use bounded S

With $\Lambda(s) = S^{-1}(s)$,

$$\boxed{\hat{s}_{\text{joint}} = \arg\min_{0<s<1} J\big(\Lambda(s); \widehat{\mu}(\Lambda(s))\big).}$$

Then $\widehat{\lambda}_{\text{joint}} = \Lambda(\hat{s}_{\text{joint}})$.

This **changes coordinates only**; the joint estimation problem still requires implementation and validation.

What is currently implemented versus future

Functionality	Research status
Fixed mu PLS fitting	Implemented
Observed-difference mu plug-in	Implemented
Conditional Gaussian MLE	Implemented
Conditional MLE search in S	Implemented
Analytical $\widehat{\mu}(\lambda)$	Mathematical derivation
Joint (λ, μ) solver	Not yet implemented
Confidence intervals for joint estimates	Not yet validated

IX. Numerical inversion algorithms

Root finding is not the same as optimizing a criterion

Invert normalized smoothness numerically

For a prescribed $s \in (0, 1)$, solve

$$F(\lambda) = S(\lambda) - s = 0.$$

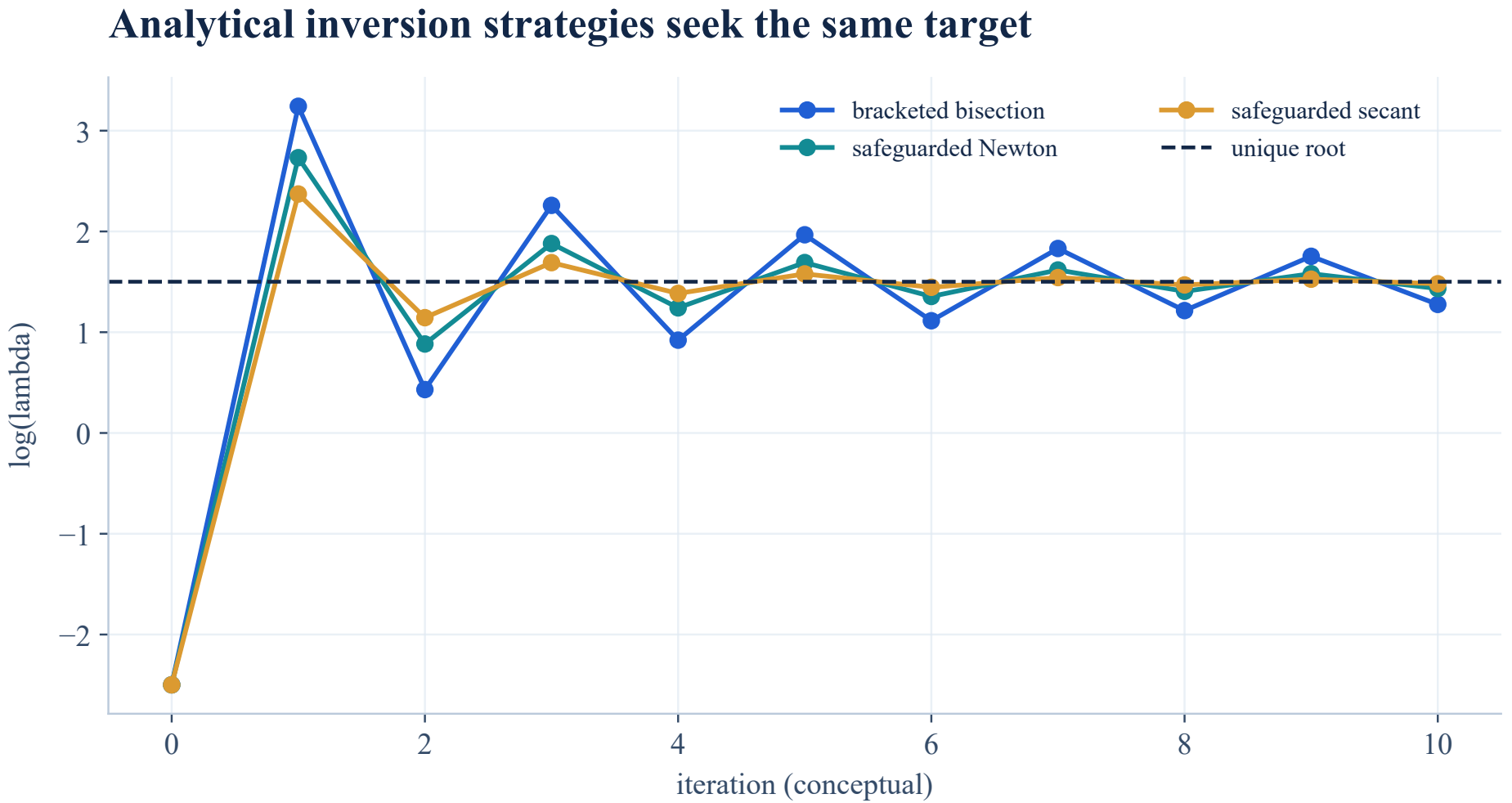
For $x = \log \lambda$, evaluate stable logistic spectral terms:

$$S(e^x) = \frac{1}{n-d} \sum_j \frac{1}{1 + \exp[-(x + \log \delta_j)]}.$$

Methods in the library: **Brent, safeguarded Newton, safeguarded secant and bisection**, plus exact special-spectrum inversion.

Endpoints $s = 0, 1$ require no root search.

Compare safeguarded root-solving ideas



Illustrative solver trajectories, not actual recorded iteration histories.

Two mathematically distinct numerical tasks

A. Invert smoothness

$$S(\lambda) - s = 0$$

has one root because $S' > 0$.

B. Select a statistical criterion

$$C'(\lambda) = 0$$

can have multiple stationary points and non-global minima.

A derivative root is not automatically the global minimum.

The actual library selection pipeline

1. Fix n, difference order d, and mean convention.
2. Precompute spectral information.
3. Choose CV / GCV / AICc / BIC / conditional MLE.
4. Choose search_space=lambda or search_space=smoothness.
5. Evaluate sampled candidates (invert S first when needed).
6. For CV, inspect analytical derivative sign changes and local valleys.
7. Compare the **original score** at admissible candidates and endpoints.
8. Return selected lambda, selected S and aligned search metadata.

A finite multi-start search cannot *prove* a global minimum.

X. Why is spectral computation potentially fast?

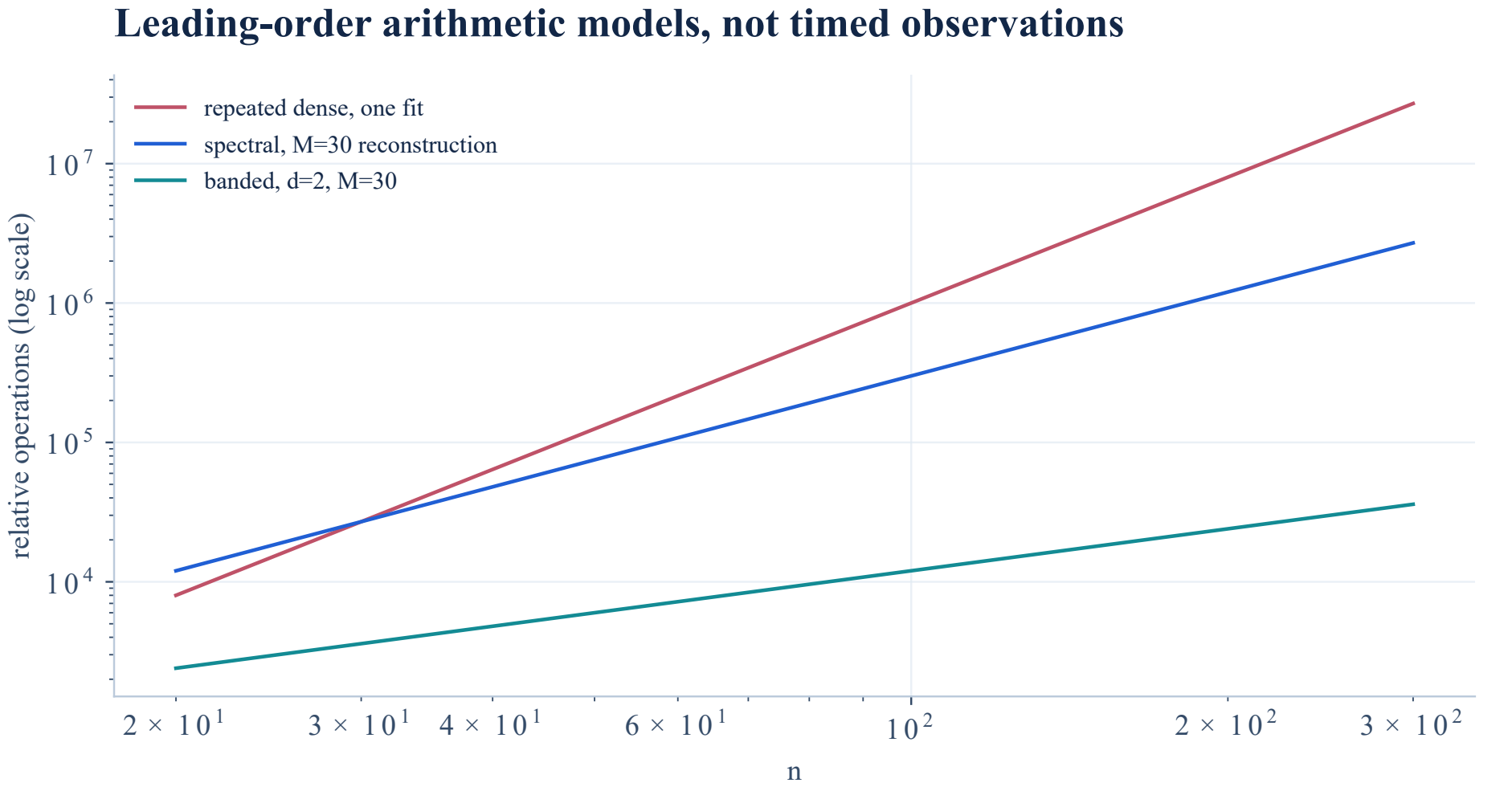
Compare identical workloads and honest baselines

Four independent implementations

Solver family	What is included
Dense fresh	Rebuild D and Q, then solve per candidate
Dense cached	Build Q once, solve dense system repeatedly
Spectral SVD	Build full SVD once, reuse basis and weights
Direct banded	Build narrow band storage and use a structured solve

The **banded baseline matters**: beating a deliberately naive dense solver alone is insufficient.

Operation-count growth is not measured elapsed time



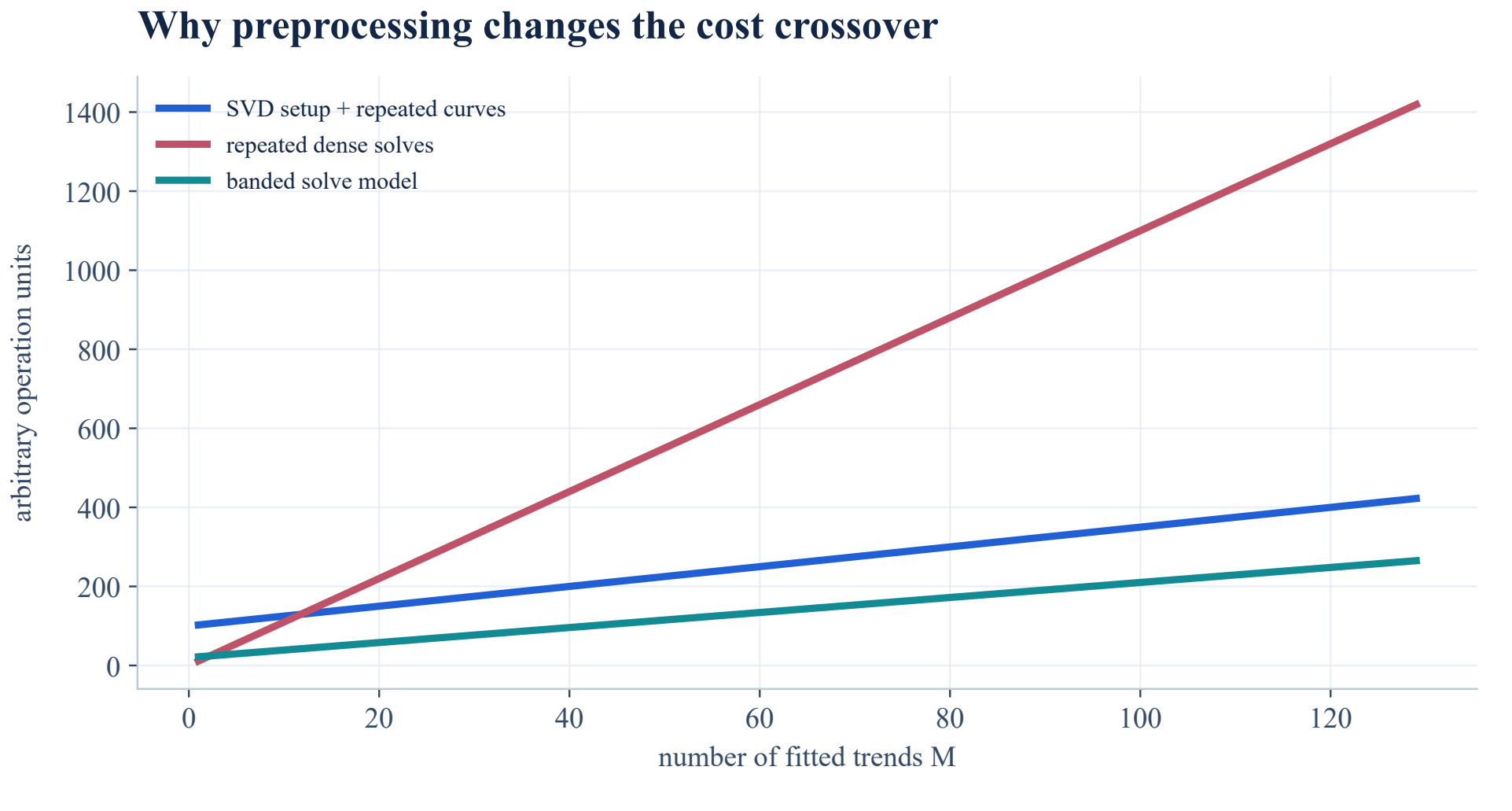
Analytical complexity models with schematic proportionality constants.

Leading work for M reconstructed trends

Method	Leading cost
Repeated dense solving	$O(Mn^3)$
One SVD plus M reconstructions	$O(n^3) + O(Mn^2)$
Banded solving at fixed d	About $O(Mnd^2)$ plus setup
Spectral trace-only queries	$O(n^3) + O(Mn)$

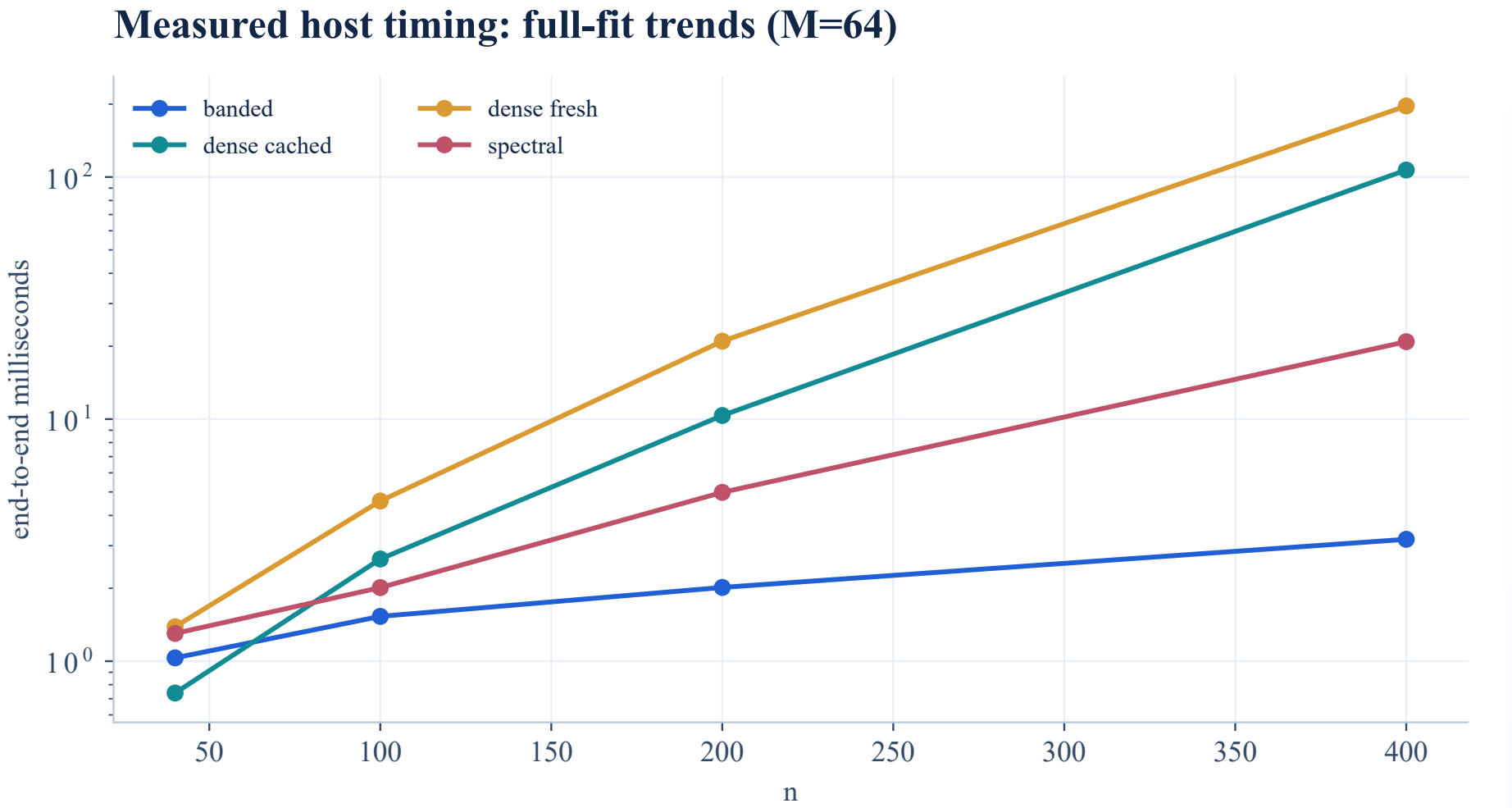
Setup, memory and actual machine effects must be included in timings.

The number of candidate penalties changes the crossover



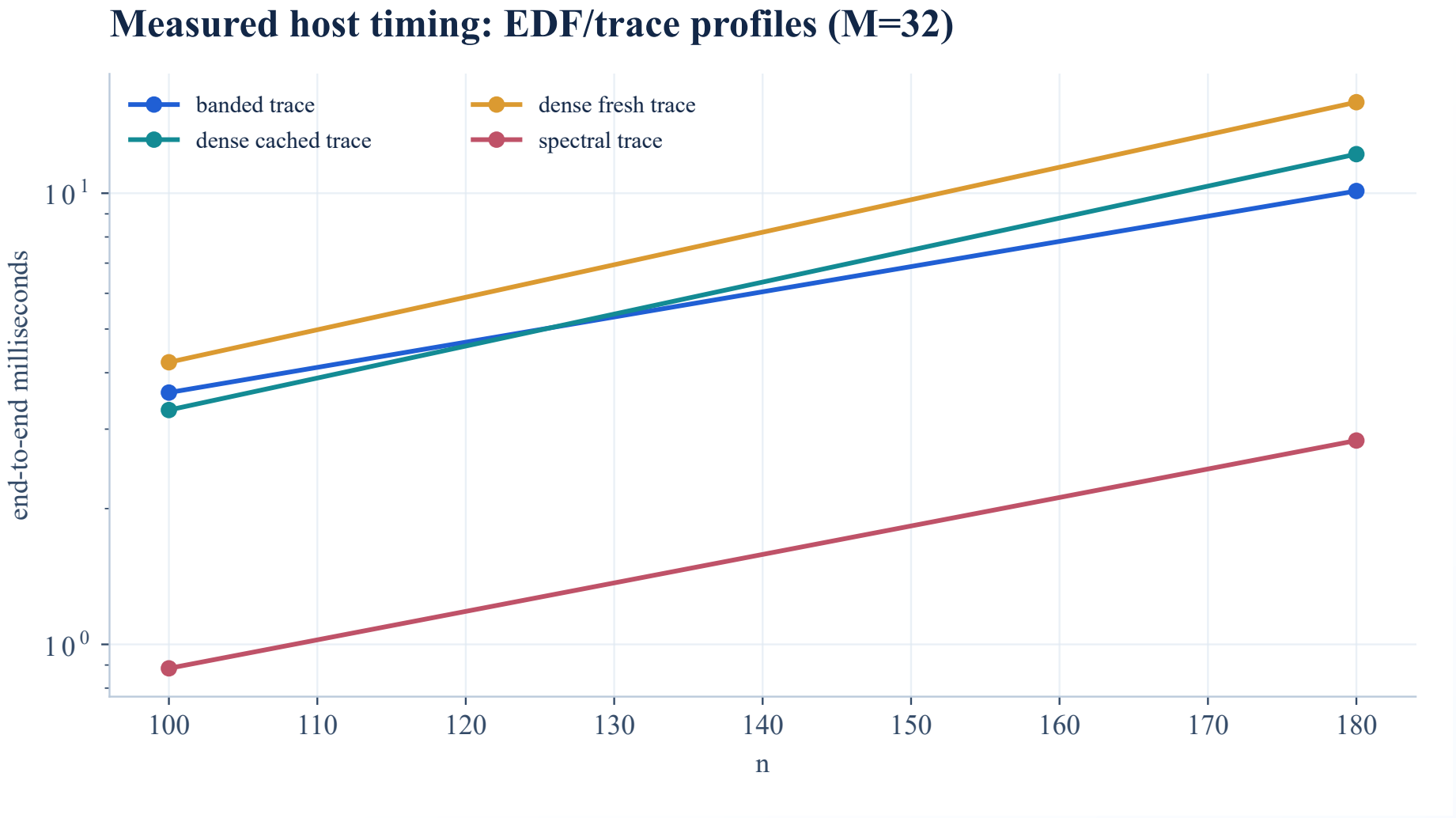
Conceptual cost model only; no invented runtime measurements.

Real host timings: full fitted-curve workload



Loads genuine host CSV when available; otherwise reports missing measurements explicitly.

Real host timings: EDF trace-only workload



A scalar trace is not the same workload as reconstructing M fitted curves.

What it would take to claim that a method is faster

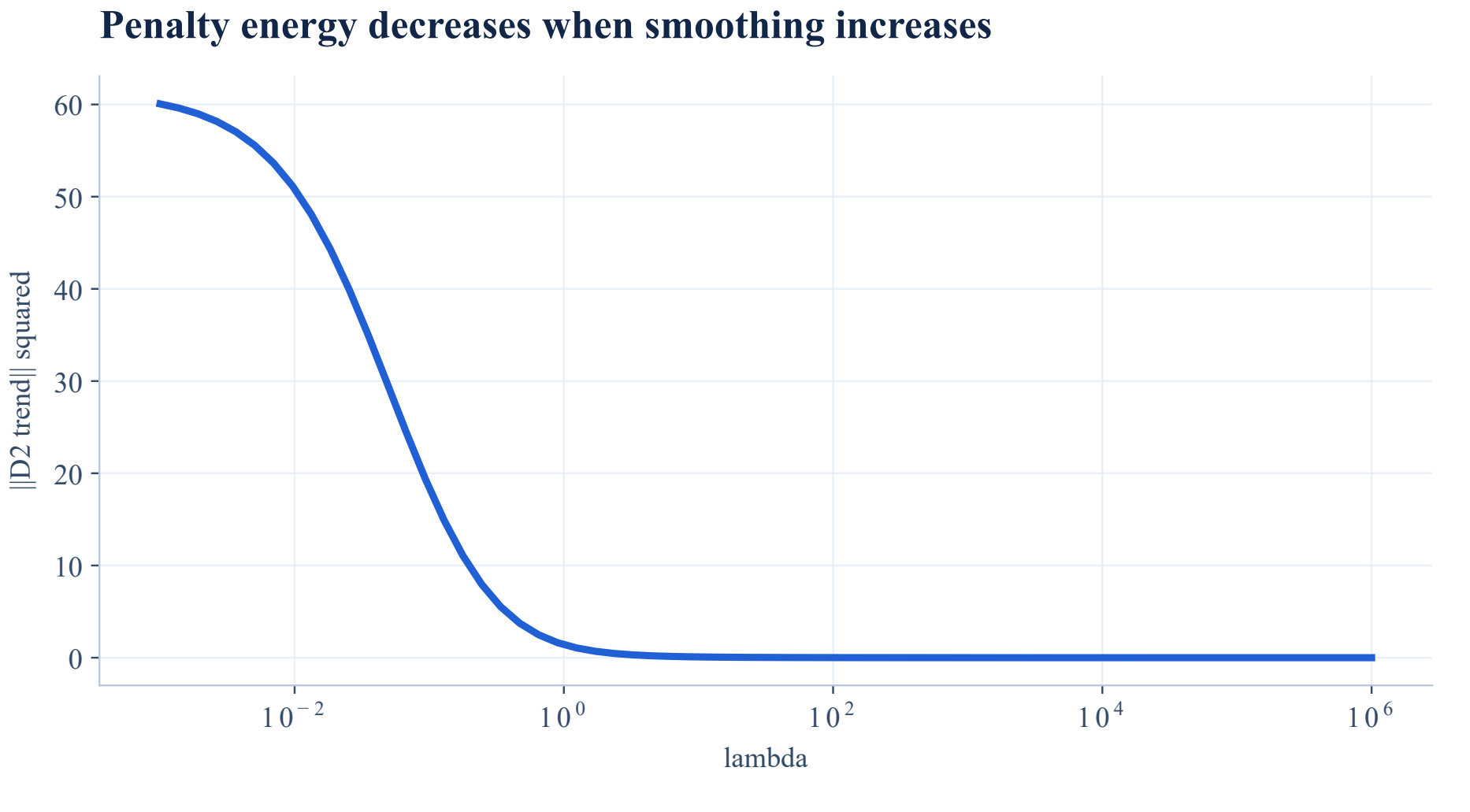
- Measure **complete end-to-end time**, including setup and M evaluations.
- Match n, d, mu, lambda candidates and numerical precision.
- Save source revision, CPU/BLAS/software versions and thread count.
- Repeat runs; report medians and dispersion.
- Record a numerical agreement tolerance against independent solvers.
- A ratio greater than one demonstrates only a **host- and workload-specific** advantage.
- Searching in S adds scalar inversion overhead not measured by the original four-solver benchmark.

No GPU or energy savings have been demonstrated.

XI. Numerical stability

Arbitrary admissible d does not imply stable floating-point computation

Penalty energy shrinks with increasing lambda



Computed with the original order-two difference operator.

Positive-spectrum conditioning grows with d



Computed from the singular values of D_d on a deterministic n=50 case.

The exact condition-ratio definition

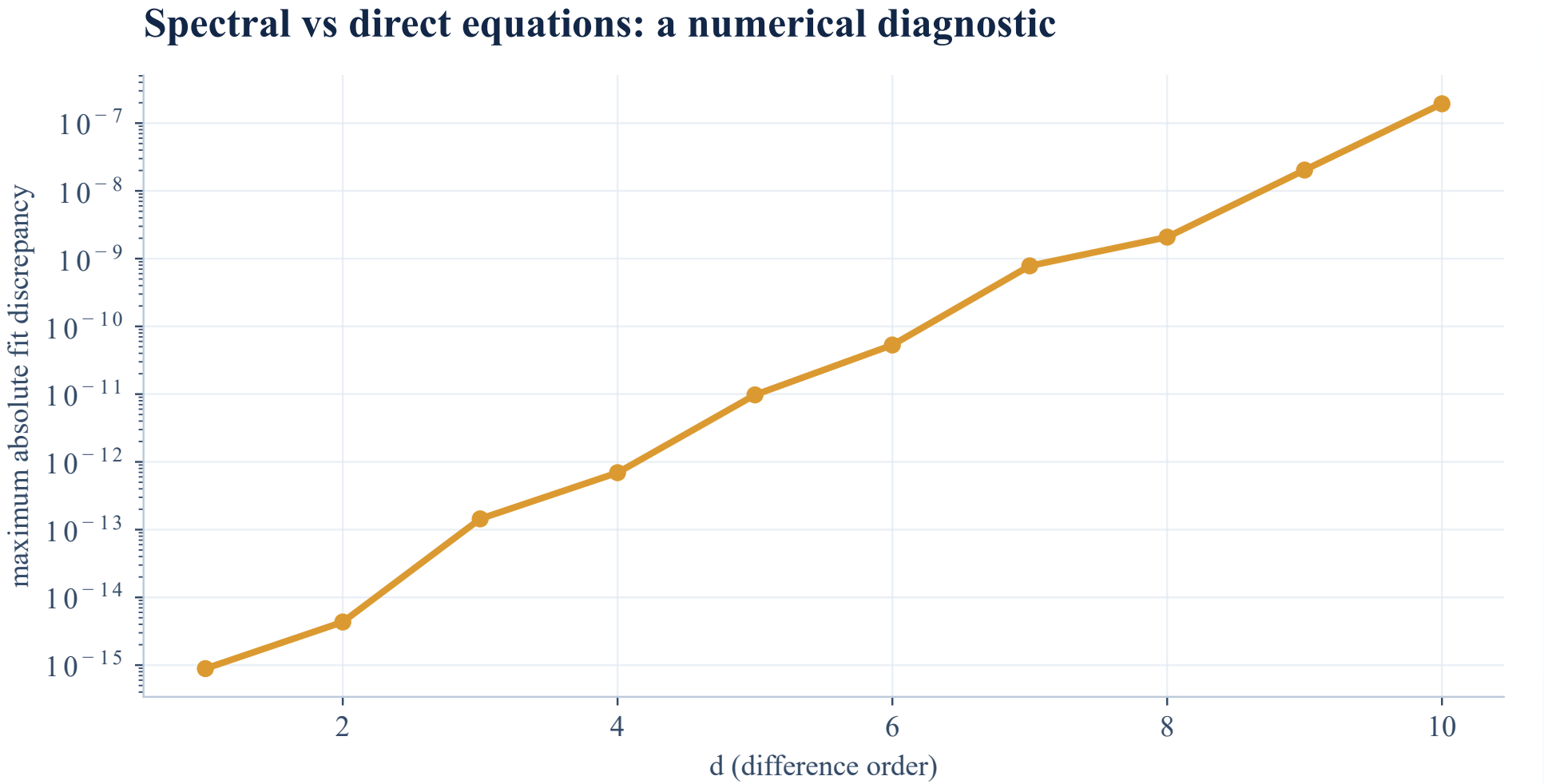
The penalty Q is singular when $d \geq 1$. Instead inspect only its strictly positive spectrum:

$$\kappa_+(Q_d) = \frac{\max_{1 \leq j \leq n-d} \delta_j}{\min_{1 \leq j \leq n-d} \delta_j}.$$

In the manuscript's higher-order diagnostic (n=50, d=1..10), this increases to approximately 2.44×10^{15} at d=10.

This is not the condition number of $I + \lambda Q_d$.

Spectral and normal-equation fits can diverge numerically



Both are float64 numerical methods; direct normal equations are not exact ground truth at high d.

Deterministic agreement checks in the paper

Paper-specific script, n=50, lambda=30, seed 20261021, and

$$d \in \{1, 2, 3\}, \quad \mu \in \{0, 0.15\}.$$

Reported maximum fitted-ordinate difference against direct normal equations: approximately 2.01×10^{-12}.

Reported infinite-penalty difference constraint error: approximately 4.42×10^{-12}.

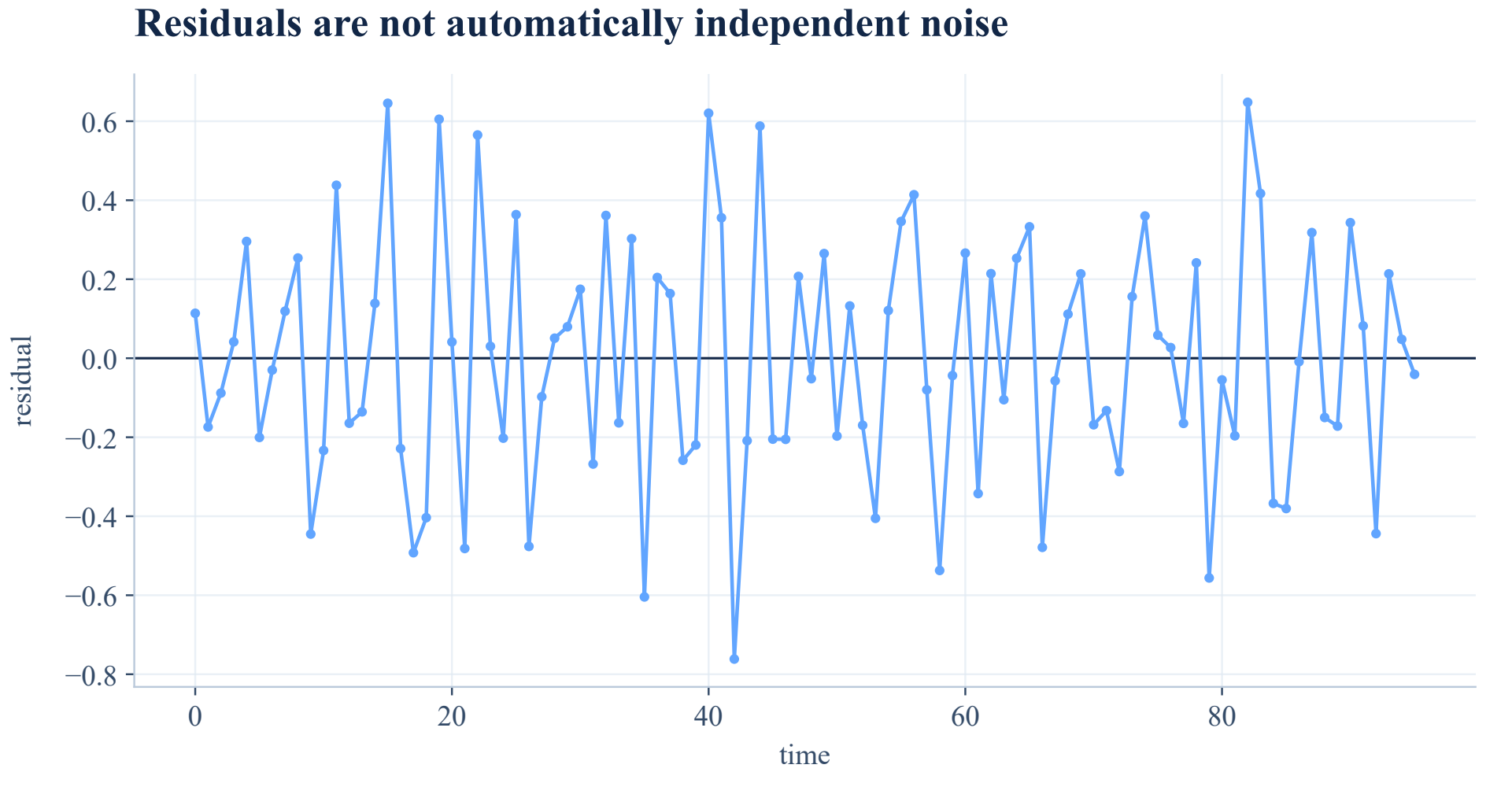
These are results for **the stated inputs**, not a general forward-error theorem.

What the new S-coordinate tests actually test

- Matched candidate penalties and normalized-S grids for d=0,1,2,4.
- Nonzero fixed mean and all classical scores.
- Analytical CV gradient in S against numerical finite differences.
- Exact endpoints, invalid coordinates and float64 extremes.
- The d=0 degeneracy: CV and GCV may tie across positive penalties.

No comparative optimization runtime was measured by those tests.

Residuals still need their own diagnostics



Smoothing does not itself imply independent or Gaussian residuals.

XII. Applications and interpretation

Illustrative synthetic truth and historical atmospheric data

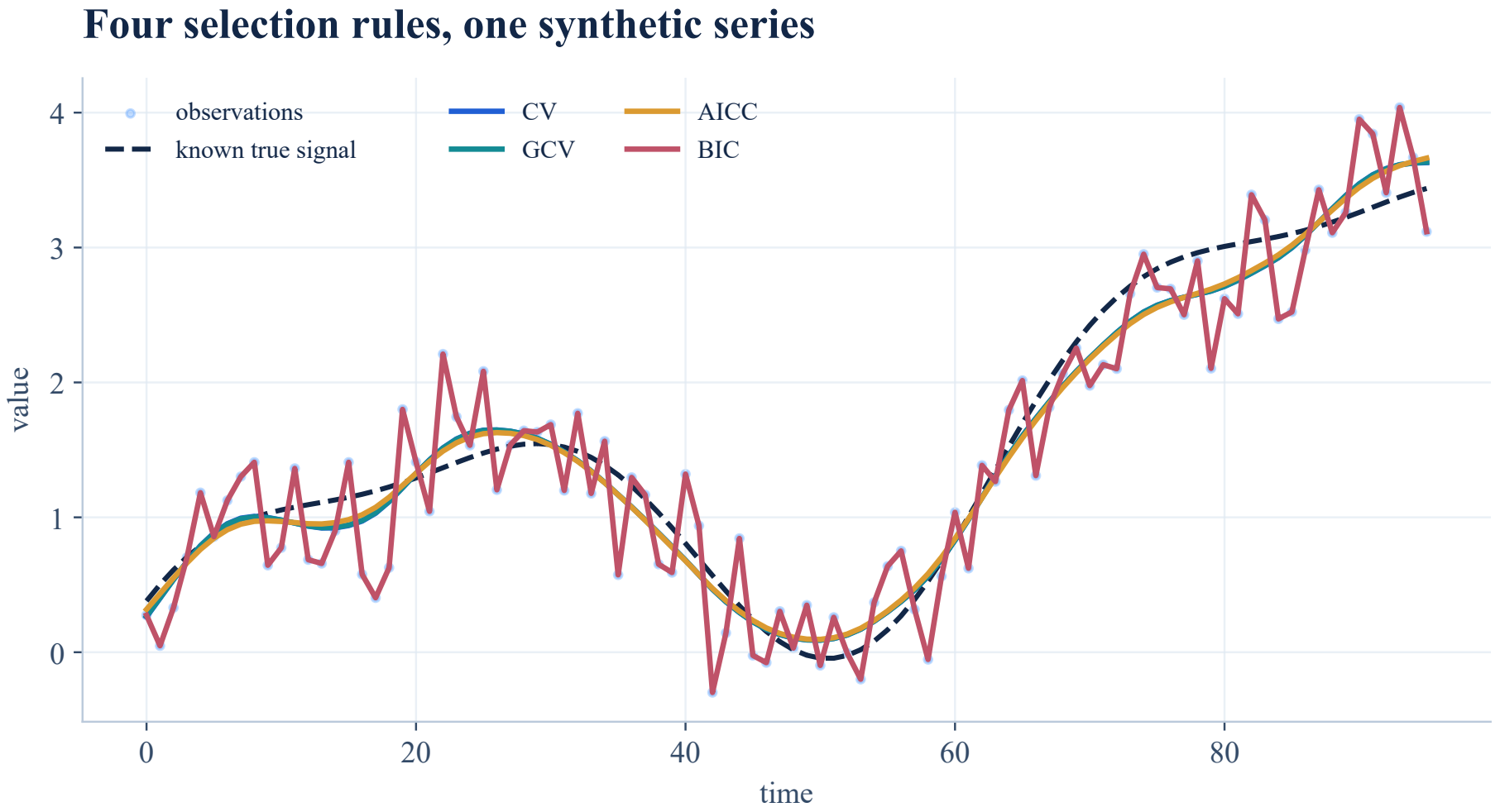
The nonlinear synthetic scenario in the paper

A Cortés-Toto-inspired single realization:

$$\tau(t) = 0.6 f_{\mathrm{Beta}(30,17)}(t/n) + 0.4 f_{\mathrm{Beta}(3,11)}(t/n).$$

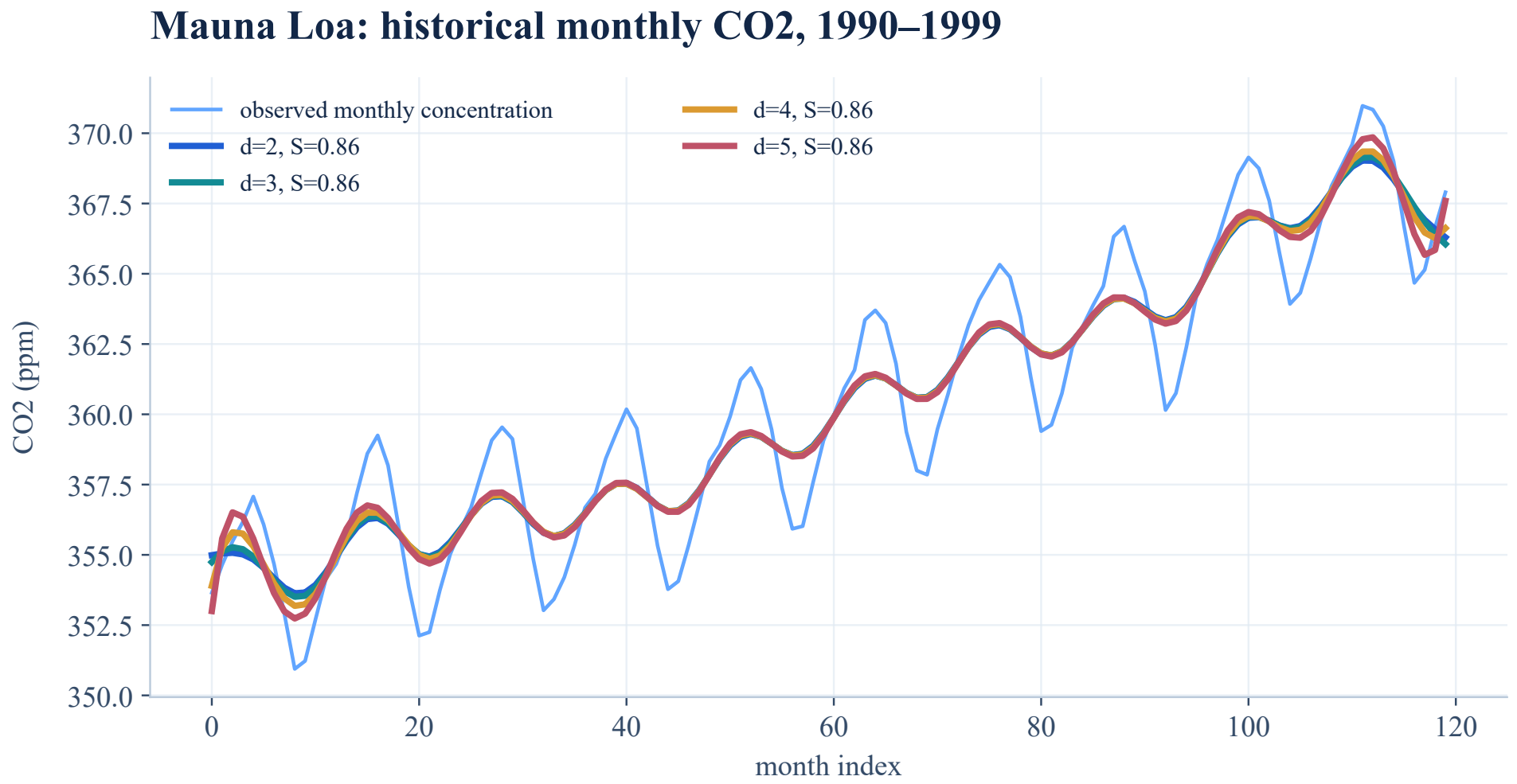
- n=50, Gaussian observation-noise SD=0.5, seed=19.
- No seasonality for this declared replication.
- d=2, fixed mu=0.
- CV/GCV/AICc/BIC on the same 121-point geometric lambda grid plus infinity.
- RMSE versus known synthetic truth is **trend recovery**, not forecast accuracy.

Criteria versus known synthetic truth



Visualized curves are deterministic; one case does not rank methods in general.

Real observations: Mauna Loa CO2, 1990–1999



Monthly averages of statsmodels weekly CO2 observations, when the optional dataset is installed.

The observational illustration uses common normalized S

The paper sets

$$\boxed{S = 0.86, \qquad \mu = 0}$$

and compares d=2,3,4,5 on 120 monthly values.

Reported penalty values: approximately 37.03, 134.01, 488.32 and 1702.30.

Seasonality in CO2 is physical structure, not automatically measurement noise. The fitted curves are **two-sided historical trends** and are not evaluated as forecasts.

XIII. What is new, exactly?

Existing theory, released software, numerical validation and future research

What must not be presented as a mathematical invention

- Finite-difference penalized least squares.
- Arbitrary positive integer difference order.
- Nonzero difference-reference means.
- Polynomial nullspaces and eigenvalue attenuation.
- Existing trace-based smoothness concepts.
- CV, GCV, AICc, BIC and Gaussian likelihood as classes of methods.

Accurate attribution makes a computational contribution more credible.

What this library integrates

- Reusable full-SVD core for an admissible integer d.
- Fixed nonzero mu and observed-difference plug-in.
- Exact infinite-penalty affine projection.
- Conditional EDF, original Guerrero index and normalized S.
- Analytical classical-LOOCV derivative with multi-candidate refinement.
- Brent, Newton, secant and bisection for inverse smoothness.
- Optional optimization over lambda or normalized S.
- Conditional Gaussian MLE and variance-component estimates.
- Four-solver host benchmark suite, regression tests, Sphinx handbook.

The bounded Computational Statistics paper

Central research question: for an established fixed-mean PLS estimator, under what workloads is reusable spectral computation accurate and competitive?

The manuscript includes:

- algebraic derivations and the normalized S coordinate;
- separate complete-fit and scalar-trace workloads;
- dense cached/fresh, spectral and banded baselines;
- numerical conditioning diagnostics;
- one synthetic and one observed-data demonstration;
- an explicit limitations section.

Joint mean likelihood estimation is kept as future work.

The repository as a reproducible research system

Mathematics: notes/ and docs/handbook/
Implementation: src/trendestimation/
Tests: tests/ and validation/
Host benchmarks: paper/benchmarks/
Manuscript: paper/main.tex and paper/sections/
Website: Sphinx documentation and notebooks
Research lecture: slides/professor_lecture/

Benchmark CSVs are host-specific: never invent values or misattribute a machine.

XIV. Research agenda and questions

Which contribution should be pursued after the paper?

Joint likelihood profiling: the next theoretical direction

Given the conditional identity

$$\boxed{\widehat{\mu}(\lambda) = \frac{\sum_j w_j b_j z_j}{\sum_j w_j b_j^2},}$$

consider

$$\boxed{\widehat{\lambda} = \arg\min_{\lambda>0} J(\lambda; \widehat{\mu}(\lambda)).}$$

Questions: identifiability, endpoints, second derivatives, robust numerical optimization, inferential properties, and simulation comparisons.

The identity is derived; the joint estimator is not a validated library feature.

An experiment that could genuinely assess S-search

1. Fix the *same* statistical criterion and data.
2. Compare direct log-lambda optimization against inverse-S optimization.
3. Match numerical tolerances and computational budgets.
4. Vary sample size, difference order, mean and selected smoothness.
5. Record criterion calls, root iterations, time including inversion, and optimum scores.
6. Include near-boundary and multiple-minima cases.
7. Repeat on specified CPU/BLAS setups with independent seeds.

Do not claim an acceleration before this is measured.

Separately: forecast-optimal smoothing

For a later forecasting paper we would need:

- An origin date and forecast horizon h.
- Rolling/expanding windows that do not use future observations.
- Separate historical price and return trends, if studying financial series.
- Forecasting baselines, uncertainty and relevant error measures.
- Multiple regimes, instruments and genuinely held-out periods.

Ordinary LOOCV and a smooth historical curve do not establish forecasting skill.

Questions for the professor

1. Is the present computational manuscript appropriately delimited?
2. Are direct banded competitors and conditioning tests sufficiently convincing?
3. Is normalized S valuable mainly for interpretation, optimization, or both?
4. Is conditional closed-form mu profiling a promising separate article?
5. What theorem or simulation would materially strengthen originality?
6. Which computations should we run on the VM next?

We should separately label established theory, tested implementation, host measurements, and open hypotheses.

Appendix. The central mathematical identities

A quick first-pass reading of the essential formulas

A1. PLS and its affine representation

$$\boxed{\widehat{\tau}_{\lambda,\mu} = \arg\min_{\tau}\{\|y-\tau\|^2 + \lambda\|D_d\tau - \mu\mathbf{1}\|^2\}.}$$

$$p_t = \mu\binom{t}{d}, \qquad \widehat{\tau} = p + H_\lambda(y-p), \quad H_\lambda = (I + \lambda D_d^\top D_d)^{-1}.$$

A2. Spectral response and residual energy

$$H_\lambda = V\,\mathrm{diag}\left((1+\lambda\delta_j)^{-1}\right)V^\top.$$

$$\nu(\lambda) = d + \sum_{\delta_j>0} \frac{1}{1+\lambda\delta_j}.$$

$$R(\lambda) = \sum_{\delta_j>0} \left(\frac{\lambda\delta_j}{1+\lambda\delta_j}\right)^2 c_j^2.$$

A3. The exact smoothness map and derivative

$$\boxed{S(\lambda) = \frac{1}{n-d} \sum_{\delta_j > 0} \frac{\lambda \delta_j}{1 + \lambda \delta_j}.}$$

$$\boxed{S'(\lambda) = \frac{1}{n-d} \sum_{\delta_j > 0} \frac{\delta_j}{(1 + \lambda \delta_j)^2} > 0.}$$

$$\boxed{\frac{dC}{ds} = \frac{dC/d\log\lambda}{dS/d\log\lambda}.}$$

A4. The four classical criteria

$$\mathrm{CV} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_i \left(\frac{e_i}{1-h_{ii}}\right)^2, \quad \mathrm{GCV} = \frac{R/n}{(1-\nu/n)^2}.$$

$$\mathrm{AICc} = \log(R/n) + \frac{2\nu+1}{n-\nu-2},$$

$$\mathrm{BIC} = \log(R/n) + \frac{\nu \log n}{n}.$$

Conditional on fixed mu; these are the library's stated conventions.

A5. Gaussian likelihood and a future profiled mean

$$w_j = \frac{\lambda \delta_j}{1 + \lambda \delta_j}, \qquad J(\lambda; \mu) = r \log\left(\frac{1}{r}\sum_j w_j (z_j - b_j \mu)^2\right) - \sum_j \log w_j.$$

$$\boxed{\widehat{\mu}(\lambda) = \frac{\sum_j w_j b_j z_j}{\sum_j w_j b_j^2}.}$$

The public likelihood search is conditional; a joint numerical method is future research.

Reproducibility and sources

How the slide deck relates to the repository

Scientific source map

Manuscript: paper/main.tex and paper/sections/*.tex
Mathematical notes: notes/smoothness_parameterization.md
Core implementation: src/trendestimation/core.py
Selection and likelihood: src/trendestimation/criteria.py and likelihood.py
Experimental scripts: paper/figures/ and paper/benchmarks/
Reference handbook: docs/handbook/

Foundational literature referenced by the paper: Whittaker (1923), Guerrero (2007/2008), Cortés-Toto et al. (2017), Weinert (2007), Biessy (2026).

The generated figure manifest records which visuals are synthetic, schematic, observed or derived from local host CSVs.

Build on Windows or the VM

```
git switch main
git pull --ff-only origin main
conda activate trendestimation
python -m pip install -e ".[plot]"
python -m pip install statsmodels

python slides/professor_lecture/make_figures.py
npm install --global @marp-team/marp-cli

powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File slides/professor_lecture/build.ps1
```

HTML and PDF are generated locally; no live website deployment occurs.

Conclusion and discussion

The research is strongest when it combines **clear established mathematics**, a reusable and tested implementation, **honest numerical comparison**, and carefully delimited novelty.

Three directions to discuss: (i) strengthen the computational paper; (ii) validate joint likelihood mean profiling; (iii) measure whether searching over S changes end-to-end optimization efficiency.

Which result should become the next theorem or experiment?